Programs

Programs are the work horses of Netrunning; they do the fighting, protecting, decrypting and sneaking for the 'Runner. If a Netrunner is a cybernetic magician, then programs are his spells, there at his mental fingertips.

"Okay, it's true I based the icon on my old input. But frack, she really did deserve to be called Soulsucker."
—Rache Bartmoss

Programs are rated by **Strength, Class, Memory Units used, Cost and ICON**:

Strength is how powerful the program is, relative to other programs. In combat, the Strength of a program is usually added to the Netrunner's attack roll (much like Weapon Accuracy in a combat situation). The higher the Strength, the better chance the program will be able to do it's job.

Class is the type of program; its function. Intrusion programs sneak in, Detection programs detect, Anti-IC programs attack other programs, and Anti-personnel programs attack Netrunners. And so on.

Memory Units represent the size of the program. All programs are measured in Memory Units, or MU. Each memory of a cyberdeck or system can hold 10 Memory Units. This means space is at a premium for Netrunners; you can only stack up so much in one run.

Cost is the price of the program on the open or black market. Nothing in the future is free. Not even the air, chombatta.

The **ICON** is what the program usually looks like in the Net. But don't count on it; you can alter your program's ICONs to suit your own tastes and style. Just goes to show; don't trust anything.

Enough talk-talk. Read the programs and spend your euro. You got a run to make.

Program List

INTRUSION

Hammer **400eb**
Class: Intrusion
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Hammer pounds down data walls with a bombardment of raw electrical pulse (use code wall attack formula on pg.142; weaken data wall Strength by 2D6 after every attack). It is very noisy and will automatically alert any defense program within 10 spaces.
ICON: A glowing red hammer.

Jackhammer **360eb**
Class: Intrusion
Strength: 2 **MU: 2**
Jackhammer is a quieter, but less powerful (weaken data wall 1D6 STR after attack) version of Hammer. It uses small pulses of energy to wear the data wall away.
ICON: A glowing red jackhammer-like object, which fires a stream of white hot energy bolts at the data wall.

Worm **660eb**
Class: Intrusion
Strength: 2 **MU: 5**
Worm is a very subtle program which emulates part of the architecture of the invaded system. It slips behind the data or code wall and opens it from the inside (2 turns, no alert).
ICON: A gold-metal, robotic worm, with green neon eyes.

DECRYPTION

Codecracker **380eb**
Class: Decryption
Strength: 3 **MU: 2**
The Codecracker series, designed by Interfact Software in 2008, is classic code gate crack program. The series disassembles the code gate at the basic program, rather than trying to decipher the key.
ICON: A thin beam of white light, which shoots from the Netrunner's hands and spreads through the code gate, turning it to glowing, dissapating fog.

Wizard's Book **400eb**
Class: Decryption (file locks & code gates)
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
The Wizard's Book is designed to scan through literally billions of possible codes and code words in seconds, trying each one in turn. It is especially effective (STR 6) against code gates.
ICON: A stream of blazing white symbols, flowing at incredible speed from the Netrunner's open hands.

Raffles **560eb**
Class: Decryption (file locks & code gates)
Strength: 5 **MU: 3**
Raffles is designed specifically to deal with complex code gates and file locks which have a specific word as the key. It asks the code gate a series of innocuous and leading questions ("Is it bigger than a breadbox?" "Is it hot or cold?"), designed to tell Raffles the nature of the code gate and its key.

"I've known bit jocks who could crack an EBM system like a cheap safe; in and out before the Icemen could even look up. Sure, they were fast and smart. But mostly, they knew their programs. They knew what to take, and when. So they never got caught off-base when the playing field turned into a battle zone. "
—Edger

ICON: A dapper young man wearing evening clothes of the early 1900's. He speaks briefly to the door, then vanishes as soon as it opens.

DETECTION/ALARM

Watchdog 610eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 4 **MU: 5**
Watchdog is designed to alert its owners to illegal entries into the system. It can do this by activating an external alarm or by sending a message to an occupied workstation. Netrunners can use Watchdogs to patrol another part of the Net, such as a rival's computer system, then key the Watchdog to run to their cybermodem or workstation if security is breached. This technique allows you to guard your secret files and pathways in other people's computers.
ICON: A large, black, metal dog . It has glowing red eyes and a spiked metal collar adorns its neck.

Bloodhound 700eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 3 **MU: 5**
Like Watchdog, Bloodhound is designed to detect illegal system entries. However, it also tracks the entry to its source and alerts its masters to the location of intruder. Like Watchdog, Bloodhounds can be set up to watch a part of the Net and report back to you at another workstation or modem.
ICON: A large, gun-metal grey hound robot. It has glowing blue eyes and wears a thick circlet of blue neon as a collar.

Pit Bull 780eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 2 **MU: 6**
The most advanced form of the Watchdog series, Pit Bull not only tracks the intruder to its source, but also cuts the line after acquiring the location. It will continue to cut the line every time the intruder logs on from that point of entry, requiring him to move to another phone line or cybermodem. Like Watchdog, Pit Bull can be set up to watch a part of the Net and report back to you at another workstation or modem.
ICON: A short, heavily built, steel dog robot. It has glowing red eyes and wears a thick circlet of red neon as a collar.

SeeYa 280eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
SeeYa is designed to detect invisible ICONS within the range of one Subgrid. This includes programs, hidden Netrunners and things hidden by Invisibility in a virtual reality.
ICON: A shimmering silver screen.

Hidden Virtue 280eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Hidden virtue is a Rache Bartmoss design used to tell "real" ICONs from other objects in a virtual reality. For example, HV could tell the difference between a real person and a virtual one or which book in a virtual library is really a data file.
ICON: A glowing green ring which the Netrunner looks through.

Speedtrap 600eb
Class: Detection/Alarm
Strength: 4 **MU: 4**
Speedtrap is an early warning program that detects the presence of an offensive program within 10 squares of the Netrunner's position (within the same subgrid). It cannot tell you where the program is, only that it exists.
ICON: A flat, glowing plate of glass, in which images appear. If a program is present, the plate fills with the image of a robotic monster. If there is no program present, the plate remains blank.

ANTI SYSTEM

Flatline 570eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 3 **MU: 2**
Flatline is designed to trace and kill the operating Interface of your cybermodem—-one zap, and your deck must have its interface chip replaced. A Flatline can be carried by an intruding Netrunner and used to attack the decks of other 'Runners encountered in the Net.
ICON: A beam of yellow neon which shoots from the Netrunner's fingertips.

Poison Flatline 540eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 2 **MU: 2**
Poison Flatline is designed to destroy not only the interface software, but the Memory of the 'deck as well. This wrecks the cybermodem, requiring total replacement. Like Flatline, Poison Flatline can be carried by an intruding Netrunner and used to attack other 'Runners encountered in the Net.
ICON: A beam of green neon which launches from the Netrunner's fingertips.

Krash 570eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 3 **MU: 2**
Krash causes the CPU of an attacked deck or system (closest CPU in multi-processor systems) to become inoperative for 1D6+1 turns. A Krashed deck automatically drops its 'runner out of the Net, while a Krashed system may not act until the time period has elapsed and it has re-booted itself.
ICON: A large, cartoon anarchist bomb, with a sizzling fuse.

DecKRASH 600eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
A modified version of Krash, which operates only on cyberdecks, causing the Netrunner to be dropped out of the Net for 1D6 turns.
ICON: A cartoon stick of dynamite with fuse.

Murphy 600eb
Class:Anti System
Strength: 3 **MU: 2**
Murphy causes the affected deck or system to randomly launch all of its applications, using as many actions as it has available to do this.
ICON: You never know...

Virizz 600eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
This virus attack automatically ties up one action of the system or deck until the deck is turned off.
ICON: A glittering DNA shape made of lights and neon.

Viral 15 590eb
Class: Anti System
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
This virus causes the affected system or deck to randomly erase one file or program each turn until the deck is turned off.
ICON: A swirling metallic blue fog with a white neon DNA helix imbedded in the center.

EVASION/STEALTH

Invisibility 300eb
Class: Evasion/Stealth
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Invisibility overlays a false signal on your cybermodem trace, making it appear to be harmless static. When activated, Invisibility will allow the Netrunner to pass unnoticed through the Net.
ICON: A flickering, iridescent sheet, which drapes over the Netrunner.

Stealth 480eb
Class: Evasion/Stealth
Strength: 4 **MU: 3**
Stealth mutes the Netrunner's cybersignal, making him harder to detect . He is still visible, but offensive programs will not react to his presence. However, other Netrunners can still see him.
ICON: a sheet of black energy draped over the Netrunner's ICON.

Replicator 320eb
Class: Evasion/Stealth **MU: 2**
Strength: 3 for most programs, 4 vs. Pit Bulls, Bloodhounds and Hellhounds
Replicator creates millions of copies of your cybermodem trace, sending them off in all directions to confuse a pursuing program. If successful, the pursuer will track the wrong signal to a dead end. Replicator is especially good against the "Dog" series of programs, as it overloads their limited AI programming structure with too many decisions.

ICON: A chrome sphere creating millions of holographic images of the Netrunner, flickering away in all directions.

PROTECTION

Shield **150eb**
Class: Protection
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Shield stops direct attack to the Netrunner. On a successful use of Shield, the attack is thwarted and no damage is taken.
ICON: A shifting circular energy field appearing in front of the Netrunner.

Force Shield **160eb**
Class: Protection
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
A more powerful version of Shield.
ICON: A flickering silver energy barrier.

Reflector **160eb**
Class: Protection
Strength: 5 **MU: 2**
Reflector is designed to repel all Stun, Hellbolt and Knockout attacks. It is unable to stop any other types of anti-personnel attacks.
ICON: A flare of blue green light, coalescing into a mirrored bowl.

Armor **170eb**
Class: Protection
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
This program is designed to slow and retard all anti-personnel attacks. On a successful use of Armor, the attack is stopped. On an unsuccessful use, Armor will reduce all Stun, Hellbolt, Brainwipe, Zombie and Hellhound attack damages by 3 points.
ICON: Glowing golden armor in a high tech design.

Flak **180eb**
Class: Protection **MU: 2**
Strength: 4 for most programs, 2 vs. Pit Bulls, Bloodhounds and Hellhounds
Flak creates a tremendous wall of static, blinding the attacking program and allowing the Netrunner to easily evade. Flak is very good against most programs, but it is relatively ineffective against the "Dog" series.
ICON: A cloud of blinding, glowing, multicolored lights, swirling in all directions.

ANTI-IC

Killer II, IV & VI **1320eb,1400eb,1480eb**
Class: Anti-IC **MU: 5**
Strength: 1 for each level of program
Killer is a general purpose virus program designed to kill other programs. It enters the logic structure of its victim and inserts errors with blinding speed, causing the target to crash (1D6 to STR). Killer is a very simple program; smooth, elegant and tough. There are many versions of Killer.
ICON: A large manlike robot, dressed as a metallic samurai. His eyes glow red from behind his mask, and he carries a glowing katana.

Manticore **880eb**
Class: Anti-IC
Strength: 2 **MU: 3**
Manticore is the simplest of a series of Assassin programs; a type of Killer designed to locate and destroy Demon programs. If no Demon is present in your cybermodem file, Manticore will ignore you.
ICON: A huge, lionlike shape, drawn in red neon schematic lines. A large scorpion tail arcs over one shoulder.

Hydra **920eb**
Class: Anti-IC
Strength: 3 **MU: 3**
A more powerful variant of Manticore.
ICON: A glittering blue fog that encircles its target and dematerializes it.

Dragon **960eb**
Class: Anti-IC
Strength: 4 **MU: 3**
The most powerful variant of Manticore.
ICON: A great golden scaled dragon robot. Laser beams shoot in multicolored arcs from its eyes, and it is wreathed in electrical discharges.

Aardvark **1000eb**
Class: Anti-IC **MU: 3**
Strength: 4 vs. Worms, no effect on any other programs.
Aardvark is designed to locate and destroy intruding Worm programs. It will immediately seek out and destroy any Worm program carried, even if it is loaded as a Demon subroutine.
ICON: A matrix of thin yellow neon lines, which surround the Worm program and close around it like a tightening net. The matrix then dematerializes with the Worm entrapped.

ANTI-PERSONNEL

Stun **6000eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 3 **MU: 3**
Stun sends an overpowering bolt of energy into the target, causing him to be frozen in place for 1D6 turns. This is a very commonly used offensive program, particularly by the NetCops.
ICON: A bolt of blue flame streaking from the Netrunner's open palm.

Hellbolt **6750eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 4 **MU: 4**
A more powerful version of Stun, Hellbolt causes physical damage (1D10 per attack) to the Netrunner. Damage is subtracted from the Netrunner as a wound until he is dead. Saves vs. Stun and Death must also be made.
ICON: A bolt of crimson fire launched from the Netrunner's raised hand.

Sword **6250eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 3 **MU: 4**
A variant of Hellbolt, Sword causes 1D6 in physical damage per hit.
ICON: A glowing energy katana.

Brainwipe **6500eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 3 **MU: 4**
Brainwipe is the simplest of a series of black programs, all of which are designed to attack the Netrunner instead of his programs. All black programs can be carried by an intruding Netrunner and used to attack other 'Runners encountered in the Net. Brainwipe tracks the victim down, fries his forebrain with a jolt of current, and reduces him to a drooling vegetable, (1D6 each turn to INT). The screaming Netrunner feels his mind melt away, until his INT is reduced to 0 and he dies. Lost INT cannot be regained.
ICON: An acid-green electrical arc, which leaps from the floor and engulfs and kills the 'runner.

Zombie **7500eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 5 **MU: 4**
An advanced and more powerful version of Brainwipe, Zombie wipes out the victim's forebrain, making him into a drooling vegetable (1D6 to INT each turn).
ICON: A shrouded, skeletal form, enveloped in a stinking grey mist. Its eyes are sunken and its flesh is a mass of rotting, maggot-filled meat. It lunges out and rips the Netrunner's head off.

Liche **7250eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 4 **MU: 4**
An advanced form of Zombie, Liche also rips away the forebrain (1D6 to INT), but selectively. Most memory is eradicated, leaving enough to implant an easily controlled (by the Referee) pseudo personality into the empty brain.
ICON: A metallic skeleton dressed in black robes and wearing a blackened crown. It grabs the Netrunner in its freezing grasp and drags him back under the floor.

Firestarter **6250eb**
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 4 **MU: 4**
Firestarter is indirectly anti-personnel in nature. Using its Bloodhound subroutines, it tracks the intruder to its source. Silently entering the electrical system, it blasts the wiring with a megawatt power surge. The jolt causes wiring fires, explosions, and fries the Netrunner as if he were in an electric chair. Firestarter programs are excellent covert killers, as they leave little or no evidence in the charred wreckage.
ICON: A blazing pillar of fire, which speaks the Netrunner's name in a hissing, booming voice, then leaps at him.

Hellhound 10,000eb
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 6 **MU: 6**
Hellhound combines the worst aspects of Pit Bull and Flatline. It locates the intruder and sends out a modulated pulse designed to cause a heart attack in humans (2D10 wound damage). If the Netrunner escapes in time, it remains active within the Net, lurking silently in major long distance terminals, waiting for the specific brain wave pattern of the intruder to show up. It then tracks him down again and kills him. Patient and remorseless, Hellhound can wait years for its victim to log on. Its rarity and high price tag prohibits its use against all but extremely high level Netrunners.
ICON: A huge, black, metal wolf. It's eyes glow white, and fire runs in ripples all over its body. It speaks in a grating, metallic voice, repeating the Netrunner's name.

Spazz 6250eb
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 4 **MU: 3**
Spazz causes epileptic seizures in the Netrunner's nervous system. REF is automatically reduced to half for 1D6 turns, slowing the Netrunner's Initiative rolls drastically.
Appearance: A nimbus of electrical energy surrounding the target.

Glue 6500eb
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 5 **MU: 4**
Used by the "Icemen" of NetWatch as an arrest program, Glue freezes the Netrunner in place for 1D10 turns (4 turns is long enough to get a good trace on his location in Realspace). The Netcops can then send a squad along to pick him up at their leisure.
ICON: A shifting pattern of red shapes flickering across the floor to entangle the Netrunner.

Knockout 6250eb
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength: 4 **MU: 3**
Knockout delivers a powerful modulated shock that knocks the Netrunner out for 1D6 hours. He is automatically dumped out of the Net, and is in a coma in Realspace for this period of time. Knockout is a very common defense against low level intrusion (like the Phone Co. or an office system).
ICON: A yellow neon schematic boxer appears and strikes out at the Netrunner's ICON.

Jack Attack 6000eb
Class: Anti-Personnel
Strength 3 **MU: 3**
Jack attack is often used as an arrest program. It stops the Netrunner from jacking out for 1D6 turns if it is successfully run.
ICON: A pair of glowing schematic handcuffs encircling the Netrunner's wrists.

CONTROLLERS

Note: Controllers are run using the CONTROL REMOTE function of the Menu, and have no ICONS.

Viddy Master 140eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Allows control of videoboards.

Soundmachine 140eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Allows control of microphones, loudspeakers, vocoders (computer voice boxes).

Open Sesamé 130eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
A low level program for opening doors, elevators, etc.

Genie 150eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 5 **MU: 1**
A high level program for opening doors, elevators, etc.

Hotwire™ 130eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Allows remote control of robotic cars, vehicles, etc.

Dee-2® 130eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Allows control of robots, cleaning mecha, autofactories, etc.

Crystal Ball 140eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Allows control of video cameras, remote sensors, etc.

News At 8™ 140eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Allows through-the-Net access to Data Terms and Screamsheet boxes for information.

Phone Home 150eb
Class: Controller
Strength: 5 **MU: 1**
Allows the Netrunner to place or receive calls in the Net. Phone Home is also Strength 2 to intercept and listen into other calls.

UTILITIES

Databaser 180eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 8 **MU: 2**
Creates open files to store information in.

Alias 160eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 6 **MU: 2**
Changes file names, replacing the filename with an innocuous title that hides its true nature.

Re-Rezz 130eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 3 **MU: 1**
Recompiles and restores damaged files or programs. If a program is de-rezzed, this is the best way to get it back short of having a copy.

Instant Replay 180eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 8 **MU: 2**
Makes a record of the Netrunner's trip, so that he can retrace his steps through the Net.

GateMaster 150eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 5 **MU: 1**
Deletes and kills Virizz and Viral 15 programs without requiring a total shutdown of the system or deck.

Padlock 160eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 4 **MU: 2**
Keeps anyone other than the Netrunner from logging onto the deck unless the proper code word is used.

ElectroLock 170eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 7 **MU: 2**
Changes an open file to a LOCKED file equal to a Code Gate of Strength 3.

Filelocker® 140eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Locks an open file to a level equal to a Code Gate of Strength 5.

NetMap 150eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Provides a locator map of most major Net regions, adding +2 to any System Knowledge check to find a place in the Net.

File Packer 140eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Compacts files to half their normal MU size. Takes 2 turns to unpack a file to normal size.

Backup™ 140eb
Class: Utility
Strength: 4 **MU: 1**
Backup allows you to make a copy of any program (except for Anti-IC and Anti-personnel types). You will need extra data chips and a cyberdeck chipreader for this.

Demon Series Programs

These are four levels of programs created by the legendary Rache Bartmoss of CCI Development in 2004. The Demon Program is a generic program with the ability to incorporate several other programs as subroutines—in short, two, three, four or even five programs in one. To use the program, you must activate the Demon, then specify the chosen subroutine it carries. **The subroutine programs look and act just as their originals, but are usually less powerful, as they must use the program strength of the Demon core in combat.**

Imp **1000eb**
Class: Demon (carries 2 programs)
Strength: 3 **MU: 3**
ICON: A small, orange sphere of light, with two amused looking red eyes. It continually emits a series of beeps, whistles and pinging noises.

Afreet **1160eb**
Class: Demon Series (carries 3 programs)
Strength: 3 **MU: 4**
ICON: A tall, powerfully built black man, dressed in elegant evening clothes and wearing a fez. He carries a dagger in his jacket, and speaks in a formal, deep voice.

Succubus **1200eb**
Class: Demon (carries 4 programs)
Strength: 4 **MU: 4**
ICON: A voluptuous, nude female form, hairless, and made from shiny chrome metal. She has large, batlike wings, and blue, pupilless eyes.

Balron **1240eb**
Class: Demon (carries 4 programs)
Strength: 5 **MU: 5**
ICON: A huge, male figure, powerfully built. He is dressed in futuristic black armor, glittering with reflected highlights. In one hand, he carries a red-glowing energy blade; his other arm ends in a series of neon-green, glowing tentacles. His eyes glow red behind his visor, and his voice is a sibilant hiss.

Copying Your Programs

A smart idea. You can copy almost any program in your arsenal. All you need is the *Backup* utility, a data chip, and a chipreader to put it in. A single chip holds 1 MU, but *Backup* is designed to break a larger file up over two or more chips.

Chips cost 10.00. To copy the contents of the average deck will cost between 100 to 300 eb. Cheap at twice the price.

Note: Anti-IC and Anti-Personnel programs cannot be *Backup*-copied; they have special copy-protection routines that erase the chip in the copy process. This makes sure you come back to your friendly local Fixer for a new copy of *Hellhound* when yours crashes. You can make a copy using your Programming Skill against a Task Difficulty of 28. But think what happens if you screw up...

Changing Programs

Chips are inserted into your deck before the start of the run. Once you're in the face, you're committed. However, if you're willing to dump out of the Net and abort the run, you can change chips (1 turn). You'll have to jack back in and retrace your steps, but this time when you meet that *Brainwipe*, you'll be *ready*.

Designing New Programs

Check out the *Designing Your Own Programs Section*, pg. 158 for details.

Live Link Up

Okay, you've got a deck and some programs. What else are you gonna need?

The last thing you're going to need is a place to plug in. This means a **phone number.**

If you're running a stationary cyberdeck, this is as simple as contacting your local office of **Internet Phone Corporation** and arranging for a phone number. The office checks your background and credit record, then issues you a Net Access code (equivalent to a 20th century phone number).

If you have a cellular phone or cellular cybermodem, the process is equally simple; call up Internet, tell them your cyberdeck's serial number, get a credit check and your Net Access code is issued to you right then and there

The Net Access code is billed a flat rate (30eb per month), plus additional costs for long distance Netruns (or calls). The bill is sent to your home on the 1st of the month. If you don't have a permanent residence, Internet will arrange to have the funds deleted out of your credit account automatically, sending a statement to wherever you get your mail.

"HMMM..." YOU THOUGHT

By now, some of you more creative types are thinking, "Hey, why not just crash into Internet's mainframe and delete my bill each month?" And we'd be disappointed if you didn't think of it— it means you're thinking like true *Cyberpunks* and that makes us proud.

But let's put it this way. You know how tough Arasaka's Tokyo Main is? Well, Arasaka still pays it's monthly bill to Internet.

These guys don't use the Net. They *own* the Net. You don't even want to guess what Internet can throw at you. It even scares Saburo Arasaka.

Note: We're not saying you *can't* jack your phone bill around (frack, it's a time honored skill of the Loyal Order of Blue Boxers & Phone Phreeks). But Referees with a consistent phone-phreeking problem should feel free to unleash the Hounds of Hell on their habitual offenders. Running from the world's largest corporation makes for a heck of an adventure.

PROGRAM LIST

Name	Class	Function	Strength	MU	Cost
INTRUSION					
Hammer	Intrusion	Knocks down data walls (2D6 per attack to data wall Strength)	4	1	400
Jackhammer	Intrusion	Knocks down data walls (1D6 per attack to data wall Strength)	2	2	360
Worm	Intrusion	Infiltrates and breaks down data walls silently in 2 turns	2	5	660
DECRYPTION					
Code Cracker	Decryptor	Breaks down code gates and file locks	3	2	380
Wizard's Book	Decryptor	Deciphers code gates (STR 6) & file locks	4/6	2	400
Raffles	Decryptor	Deciphers code gates & file locks	5	3	560
DETECTION/ALARM					
Watchdog	Detect/Alarm	Detects entry and alerts owner	4	5	610
Bloodhound	Detect/Alarm	Detects entry and traces signal, then alerts master	3	5	700
Pit Bull	Detect/Alarm	Detects entry, traces signal and cuts intruder's line until killed	2	6	780
SeeYa	Detect/Alarm	Detects "Invisible" ICONS	3	1	280
Hidden Virtue	Detect/Alarm	Detects "real" things in virtual realities	3	1	280
Speedtrap	Detect/Alarm	Detects hidden programming within 10 spaces	4	4	600
ANTI SYSTEM					
Flatline	Anti System	Kills operating CPU	3	2	570
Poison Flatline	Anti System	Kills all system Memory	2	2	540
Krash	Anti System	Crashes system CPU for 1D6+1 turns	3	2	570
DecKrash	Anti System	Crashes deck CPU for 1D6 turns. Drops opponent out of Netspace	4	2	600
Virizz	Anti System	Ties up 1 action of system till deck is turned off	4	2	600
VIRAL 15	Anti System	Erases one file randomly each turn	4	2	590
Murphy	Anti System	Causes system to randomly launch programs	3	2	600
EVASION/STEALTH					
Invisibility	Evasion	Hides cybersignal, making you appear "invisible"	3	1	300
Stealth	Evasion	Mutes cybersignal, making it harder to detect	4	3	480
Replicator	Evasion	Confuses attacking IC by creating millions of deck signals	3/4	2	320
PROTECTION					
Shield	Protection	Stops attacks to Netrunner	3	1	150
Force Shield	Protection	Stops stronger attacks to Netrunner	4	2	160
Reflector	Protection	Reflects and stops *Stun, Hellbolt, Knockout* attacks	5	2	160
Armor	Protection	Reduce *Stun, Hellbolt, Brainwipe, Zombie, Hellhound* attacks by -3 pts.	4	2	170
Flack	Protection	Creates static walls to blind attackers. STR 2 vs DOG series programs	4/2	2	180
ANTI-IC					
Killer II	Anti IC	Attacks all types, 1D6 damage to target STR. Mobile	2	5	1320
Killer IV	Anti IC	Attacks all types, 1D6 damage to target STR. Mobile	4	5	1400
Killer VI	Anti IC	Attacks all types, 1D6 damage to target STR. Mobile	6	5	1480
Manticore	Anti IC	Attacks *Demons*, de-rezzing instantly	2	3	880
Hydra	Anti IC	Attacks *Demons*, de-rezzing instantly	3	3	920
Dragon	Anti IC	Attacks *Demons*,derezzing instantly	4	3	960
Aardvark	Anti IC	Detects and attacks *Worms*, de-rezzing instantly	4	3	1000
ANTI-PERSONNEL					
Stun	Anti-Person.	Freezes Netrunner for 1D6 turns	3	3	6000
Hellbolt	Anti-Person.	Cause 1D10 physical damage to Netrunner	4	4	6750
Sword	Anti-Person.	*Hellbolt* variant, causes 1D6 physical damage to Netrunner	3	4	6250
Brainwipe	Anti-Person.	Reduce INT by 1D6 each turn, killing Netrunner	3	4	6500
Zombie	Anti-Person.	Reduce INT by 1D6 each turn, leaving Netrunner mindless	5	4	7500
Liche	Anti-Person.	Erases memory, replacing with pseudo-personality	4	4	7250
Firestarter	Anti-Person.	Causes power surge, starting fire in Netrunner's deck.	4	4	6250
Hellhound	Anti-Person.	Tracks Netrunner, waits, then causes 2D10 damage/turn	6	6	10,000
Spazz	Anti-Person.	Reduces Netrunner REF for 1D6 turns	4	3	6250
Glue	Anti-Person.	Locks Netrunner in place for 1D10 turns	5	4	6500
Knockout	Anti-Person.	Causes coma for 1D6 hours	4	3	6250
JackAttack	Anti-Person.	Prevents Netrunner from logging off	3	3	6000
CONTROLLERS					
Viddy Master	Controller	Video board controller	4	1	140
Soundmachine	Controller	Microphone/voxbox controller	4	1	140

Open Sesamé	Controller	Electronic door controller	3	1	130
Genie	Controller	More powerful door, elevator controller	5	1	150
Hotwire™	Controller	Vehicle controller	3	1	130
Dee-2®	Controller	Robot controller	3	1	130
Crystal Ball	Controller	Video/camera controller	4	1	140
News At 8	Controller	Screamsheet box controller	4	1	140
Phone Home	Controller	Send & receive cellular calls, intercepts calls at STR. 2	5	1	150
UTILITIES					
Databaser	Utility	Stores up to 10,000 pages per file of information/text	8	2	180
Alias	Utility	Replaces file name with false one	6	2	160
ReRezz	Utility	Recompiles and restores destroyed programs	3	1	130
Instant Replay	Utility	Records coordinates of current Netrun for replay later	8	2	180
Gatemaster	Utility	Detects and destroys *Virizz, Viral 15* programs	5	1	150
PadLock	Utility	Refuses to allow log on through deck unless code is given	4	2	160
Electrolock	Utility	Locks files as is a STR. 3 code gate.	7	2	170
FileLocker®	Utility	Locks files, requiring code word (runner's choice) to open	4	1	140
NetMap	Utility	Provides accurate maps of most well-known Net locations	4	1	150
Packer	Utility	Reduces programs by 1/2 size. Take 2 turns to unpack	4	1	140
Backup	Utility	Creates copies of most programs on chip	4	1	140
DEMON SERIES					
Imp II	Demon	Carries 2 programs	3	3	1000
Afreet II	Demon	Carries 3 programs	3	4	1160
Succubus II	Demon	Carries 4 programs	4	4	1200
Balron II	Demon	Carries 4 programs	5	5	1240

Didn't pay your bill this month? Internet gives you thirty days to pay up, with polite reminders at the end of the thirty. Past sixty days, Internet automatically deletes your Net Access code . From then on, the code is invalid and you just don't make calls. Period. For a 1,000eb deposit, you can get a new Net Access Code.

Maybe.

Past 120 days, Internet scrambles a Solo team and starts looking for you. Collections in the 21st Century is a rapidly expanding field, with exciting new developments in man portable weapons, brainwipe and behavior adjustment through selective use of adversive pain therapy.

Just so you know.

You don't *have* to have a Net Access code. You can jack a deck into someone else's line (making yourself really popular with your cube mate), or even jack into a street Data Term. However, at 1eb per minute plus long distance charges, this can be an expensive proposition. You also have to put the euro right up front to log on.

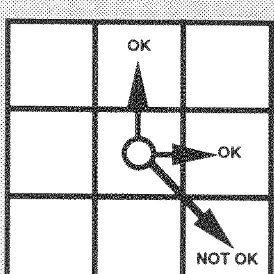
This may be one reason why a favorite tactic of Netrunners is to sneak into a big corporate office building where they can log on using the corporation's phones to make their runs. This is illegal and dangerous(corporate guards aren't known for a sense of humor), but it is free. And that's a powerful incentive for some people.

Got a Net Access code? Let's get busy.

LONG DISTANCE CHARGES

Count the number of spaces between your starting point and your ending point. Multiply this by .20 eb per turn spent in the Net to determine how much you're charged. *Example: Our run from Night City to London covers eight spaces and takes two turns. The cost of the call will be 3.20eb.*

Terminology Note: Net Turn and Net Round are used interchangeably throughout this chapter.



MOVEMENT IN THE NET

Running the Net

Okay, let's start with the basics.

First, you gotta know how to move around. That's easy. Each turn in the Net, you can move five spaces, no matter how big those spaces are. On the **Net World Map** (pg. 146), a single space is a thousand square miles. On a **City Grid Map**, a single space is about a dozen blocks. On a **Subgrid Map** (one square of a City Grid Map), a single space is roughly a few yards. No matter where you are, you still move five spaces per turn.

Howzat?? Look, chombatta, in reality, you're not moving at all— it's just your point of view that's moving. Think of it like you're sending out an eyeball on a long string. The eyeball travels, but you don't.

In the Net, things move fast. Speeds are measured in nanoseconds, not even seconds. We meat minds are turtles compared to the big systems and the AIs. To get things down to a scale we humans can comprehend, the Interface program in your deck scales time down to match your perceptions. In real time, you may have just moved two thousand miles in one second. But you just perceive it as "teleportation"— zap; you're there. When distances are smaller, the Interface program slows things down so that you don't crash through the sides of some honcho's data fortress.

Five spaces per one second turn. It's the Law.

Second rule. All travel in the Net is done in straight lines. This means you go through the sides of a space, not the corners (see illustration). Sure, real people cut the corners all the time. But remember, you aren't really moving at all. The space you're not moving through doesn't really "exist", and even if it did, the perception of volume is a creation of the old I-G Transformations. So you play by the Interface's rules in the Net. Got it?

Okay, so now we're moving.

On the Net World Map (pg. 146), we move by going from one Long Distance Link (LDL) to the next. Say you want to go from Night City to London. You can't just teleport to London. No, you'll have to go through a series of short 5 square hops to get where you want to go.

You do this by locating the furthest Long Distance Link (LDL) within your five space range. From Night City, this means your options would be Salt Lake, Denver, Atlanta, Chicago, New York/BosWash, New Orleans and Havana. You couldn't jump the whole way; at five spaces per turn, you'd end up stranded in the ocean without an LDL to stop at.

So you jump from Night City to New York. From there, you can easily jump to London; it's five spaces exactly. But wait a sec... There's one more thing you need to consider. **Security Levels.**

Security Levels

If you're going to be making a legal long distance jump, going to New York is no problem. But face it; you don't want to spend a lot of euro on long distance charges. You want to run that old LONG DISTANCE LINK command on the Menu and blast on through.

That's where Security Levels come in. Each LDL is ringed with codes and defenses to keep you from logging free calls on Internet's phone tab. These defenses are reflected in the LDL's Security Code; a value you must roll a 1D10 value equal or higher than in order to scam the system. If you fail the roll, you've been caught. Worse, your actions may alert the ever-vigilant NETWATCH goons, who will track you down and drag you off to Death Valley Maximum Security Prison. Roll 1D6 and see what happened:

- 1-4 You are cut off the line & are charged for the call (see Sidebar, pg. 142).
- 5 You are cut off and NETWATCH is given your access code. Expect a friendly visit in Realspace soon.
- 6 The NetCops try to bust you on the spot (Roll 1D6)
  - 1-2 They fine you 1D6x100eb.

3-5 You escape. They don't have a trace on you, but will spend 1D6+1 days patrolling that area of the Net hoping you'll show up.
6 You escape, but they issue an ANB (All Net Bulletin) on you. They know you're out there, and they're looking for you. It's only a matter of time...

Often, it's smarter to take the long way around when approaching a target city, moving through low security LDLs instead of jamming right through the high security ones.

Tracing

There's another reason to pick your LDLs carefully. Besides having a Security Level, each LDL also has a **Trace Value.** The trace value represents the difficulty of tracking your cybersignal through that particular LDL. Each LDL you pass through has it's own Trace Value; the total value of all LDLs passed through in a Net run represents the Difficulty of tracing your signal back to it's source. By picking the right LDLs, or by going through a *lot* of them, you can make it nearly impossible to trace your point of origin.

This is important, particularly if you are being attacked by a program with some type of tracing function built into it. For example, if a *Hellhound* fails to nail you before you jack out, it must attempt to trace your signal in order to execute it's backup program (find out where the Netrunner entered the Net and wait till he reenters— then kill him).

To trace you, the program must roll a 1D10 + Strength value equal to or greater than the total of all the Trace Values you have passed through on your trip. If the program fails this roll, it will not be able to get a trace on your signal.

City Grids

Once you hit your target city, it's time to move to the **City Grid** map. This is an overall map of the city; much like a Realspace map, the City Grid Map shows the locations of important places in the city— in this case, important systems and Data Fortresses. You enter the City Grid map through the LDL ICON on the map, then move at five spaces per turn to where your target system is located.

We've given you a sample City Grid based on Night City. As a Referee, you'll want to construct your own City Grids; there's a blank map for this purpose as well. If you have a really large city, you may want to use several City Maps placed end to end.

Each Data Fortress on the City Grid has an identifying ICON on the City Grid Map. These ICONS are coded by the level of security the system is known to have.

Grey Systems: These systems utilize only Alarm and Detection programs. They include most City governments, Universities and small private businesses.

Level 1: These systems include small corporations, police services and large private businesses. Anti-IC programs are used in these systems, as well as Detection and Alarm programs.

Level 2: Anti-IC and anti system programs are used here. These systems include medium sized corporations and very large private businesses.

Level 3: These systems use non-fatal anti-personnel programs. Level three systems are usually operated by large corporations, state governments and other moderately powerful groups. These people don't want you in their systems, but they don't have the clout to waste you out of hand. They'll just hurt you and hand you over to NETWATCH.

Black Systems: These fortresses use fatal and non-fatal anti-personnel software. Black systems include multinational corporations and government agencies like the CIA. They know you have no business being in their system, and they don't care what your lawyers think about them. They're willing to bury both you and the ACLU in the landfill, and have the clout to do it.

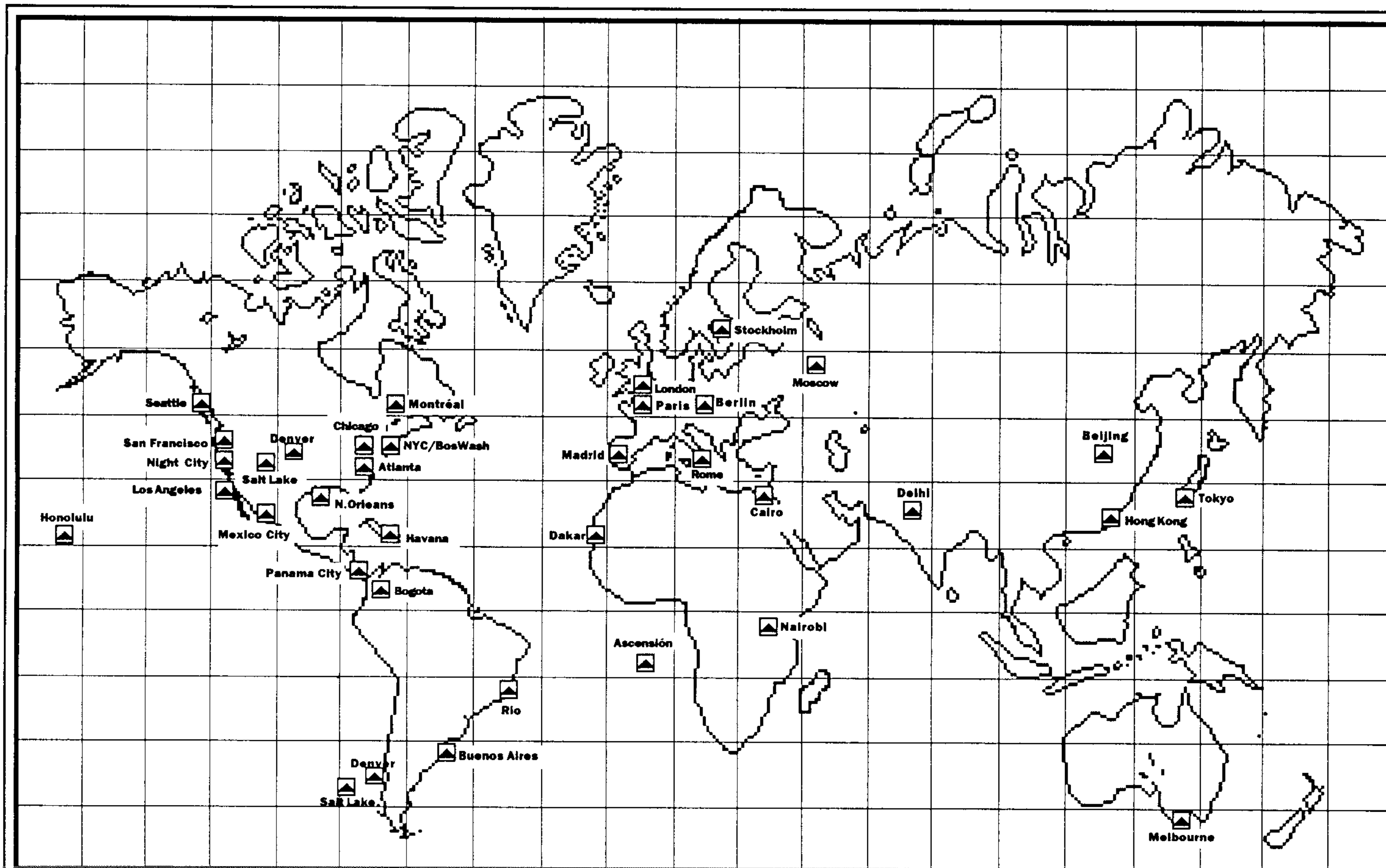
HANGING OUT

If the system you want to visit is off line or shut down, there's going to be a blank space in the Net instead of a Data Fortress ICON. You may have to wait around a while before your target shows up. For example, if First Eurobank has 9-5 hours, this means you may have to wait until the bank comes on line.

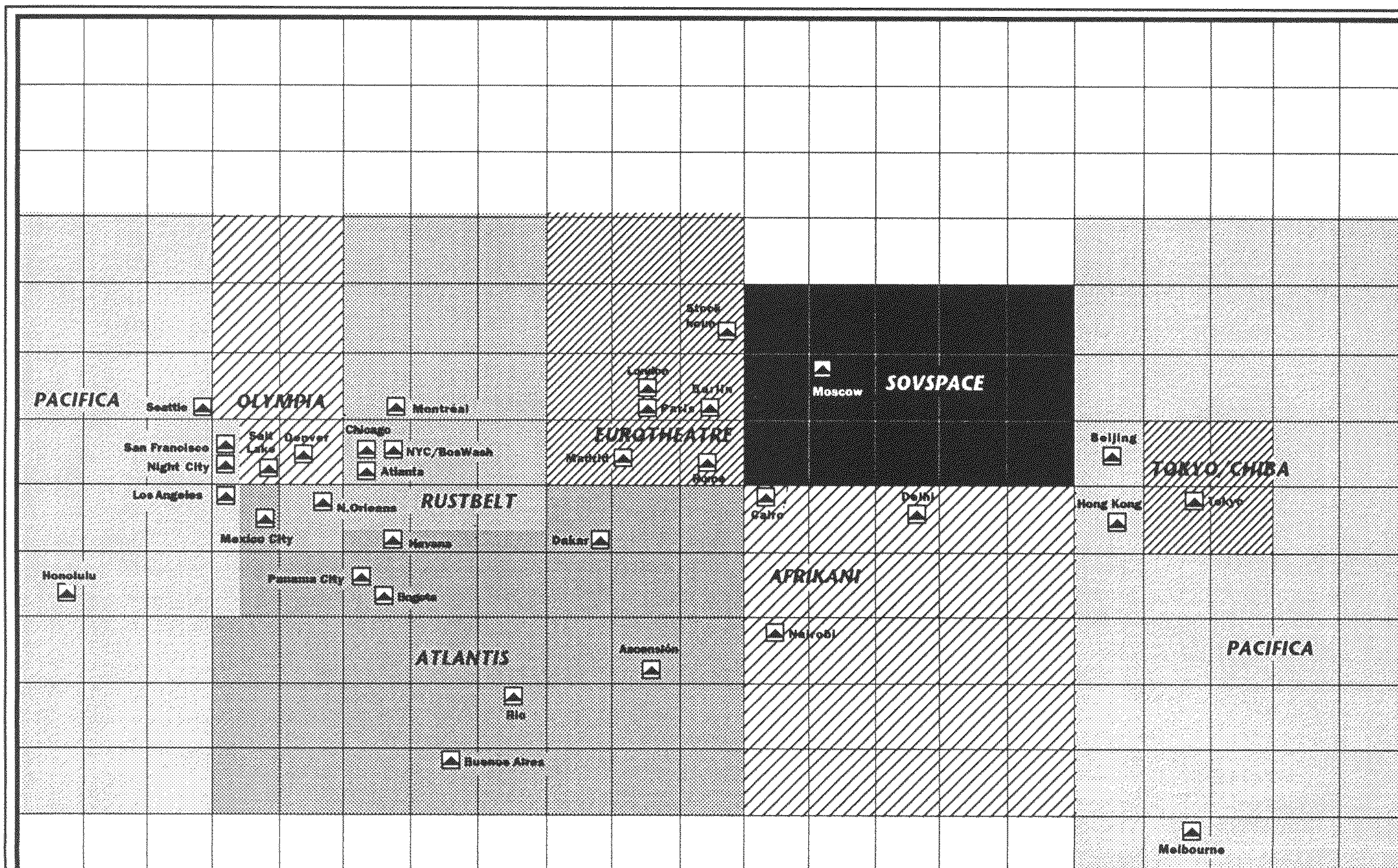
So there you are, hanging out. Sooner or later, you're going to meet someone...

RANDOM NET ENCOUNTERS

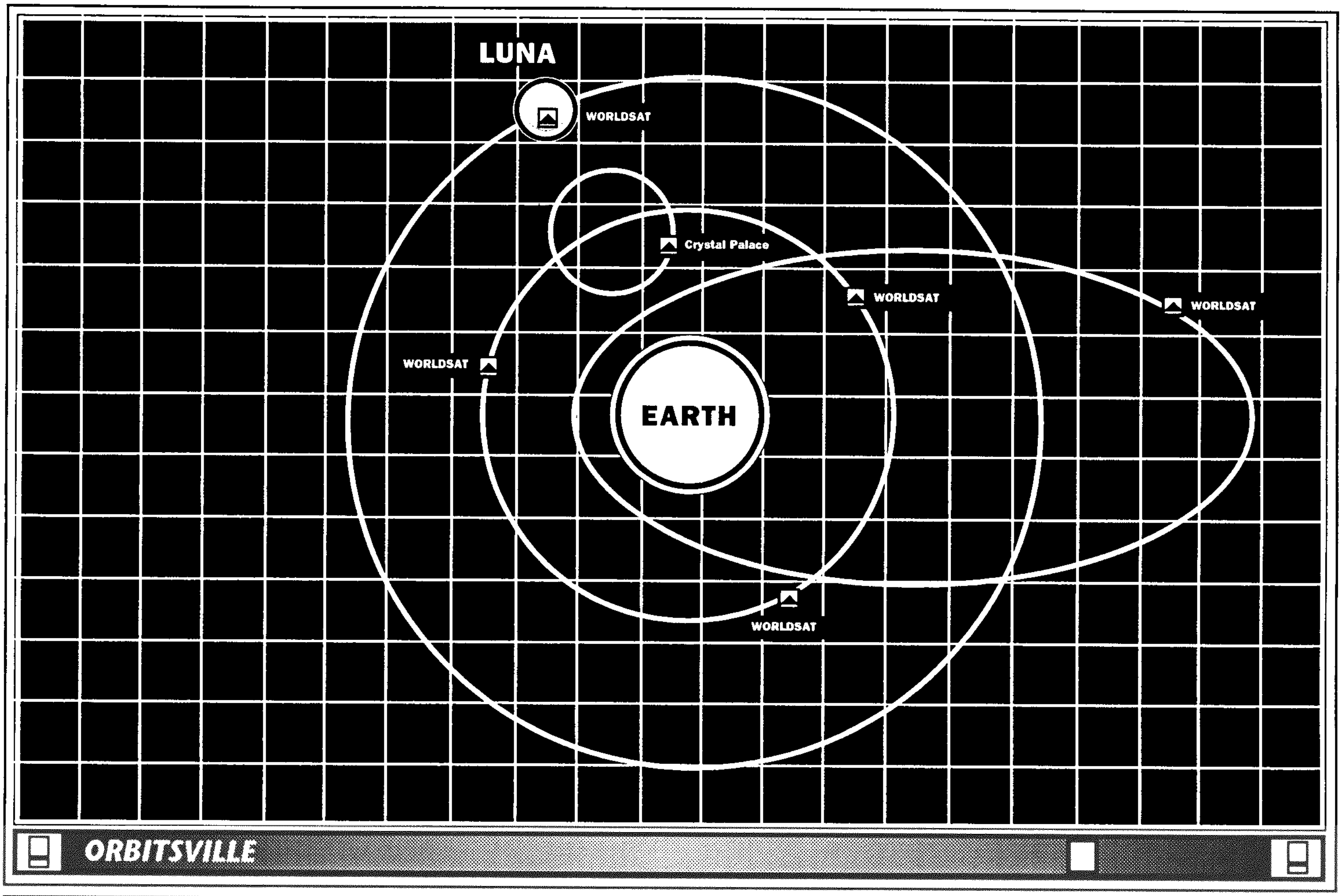
1-2 Nothing
3 Random Program passes.
4 Friendly Netrunner
5 Hostile Netrunner
6 NETWATCH



WORLD NET MAP (REALSPACE)

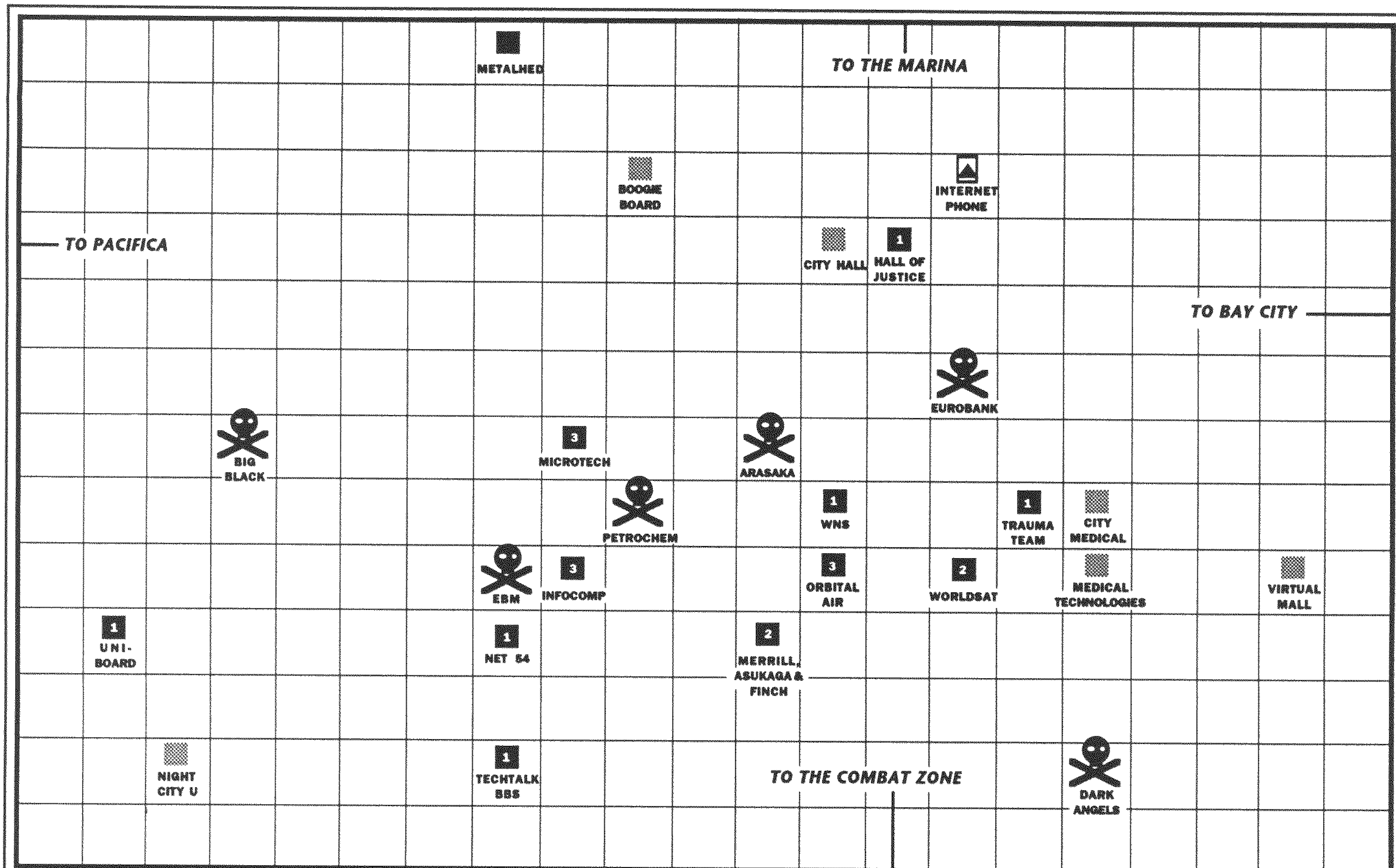


WORLD NET MAP (NETSPACE)

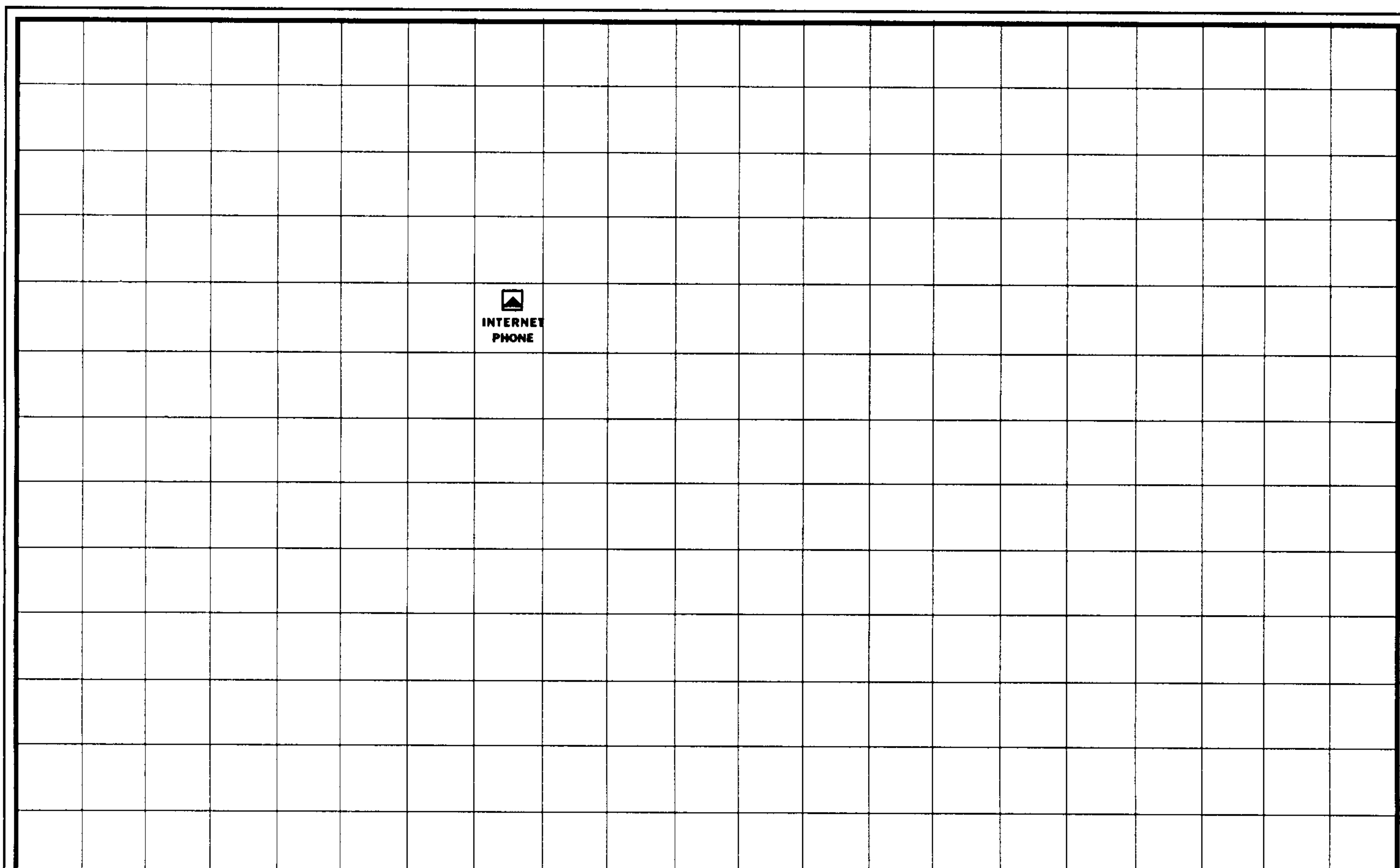


LONG DISTANCE LINK GUIDE

City	Region	Controlled by:	Security Lvl.	Trace Value
Ascensíon	Atlantis	Central American Federation	2	3
Atlanta	Rustbelt	NetWatch /US Govt. /EuroMarket Consortium	2	3
Berlin	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	3	3
Bogota	Atlantis	Central American Federation	1	4
Buenos Aires	Atlantis	Central American Federation	2	3
Cairo	Afrikani	Orbital Air	4	4
Chicago	Rustbelt	NetWatch /US Govt. /EuroMarket Consortium	2	2
Crystal Palace	Orbitsville	ESA	2	3
Dakar	Afrikani	None	2	2
Denver	Olympia	NetWatch /US Govt./Orbital Air	2	1
Delhi	Afrikani	None	1	2
Havana	Atlantis	Central American Federation	2	3
Honolulu	Pacifica	NetWatch /US Govt./EBM	2	2
Hong Kong	Pacifica	NetWatch/ Far Asian Co-Prosperity Sphere	2	3
Luna	Orbitsville	ESA	2	4
London	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	3	2
Los Angeles	Pacifica	NetWatch /US. Govt./ Petrochem	2	2
Madrid	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	3	2
Melbourne	Pacifica	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	2	2
Mexico City	Atlantis	Central American Federation	1	2
Montreál	Rustbelt	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	2	2
Moscow	SovSpace	USSR / EEC	3	2
New Orleans	Rustbelt	NetWatch /US Govt. /EuroMarket Consortium	2	3
New York/BosWash	Rustbelt	NetWatch /US Govt. /EuroMarket Consortium	3	1
Nairobi	Afrikani	Orbital Air	2	2
Night City	Pacifica	NetWatch /US Govt. /Arasaka	2	2
Panama City	Atlantis	Central American Federation	1	3
Paris	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	3	2
Beijing	Pacifica	Far Asian Co-Prosperity Sphere	3	2
Rio De Janiero	Atlantis	Central American Federation	2	2
Rome	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	2	2
Salt Lake	Olympia	NetWatch /US Govt./ Militech	2	1
San Franscisco	Pacifica	NetWatch /US Govt./EBM	2	2
Seattle	Pacifica	NetWatch /US Govt./ Arasaka	2	2
Stockholm	EuroTheatre	NetWatch /EEC/ Eurocorps	3	2
Tokyo	TokyoChiba	Arasaka/ Zaibatsus/ Far Asian Co-Prosperity Sphere	3	2



CITY GRID MAP (NIGHT CITY)



YOUR OWN CITY GRID MAP

As in all Net movement, 'Runners move at a rate of five squares per turn. Movement, of course, is in straight lines, and cannot (obviously) pass through an obstacle unless you blast it to oblivion first.

Once you're down to the subgrid level, Netrunning becomes pretty simple. You try to get into the Data Fortress, either by getting through a Code Gate, or by blasting through a wall. Once inside, you move from place to place, looking for Memories to loot and other useful things. Along the way, you'll encounter various anti-intrusion programs and traps, all of which are programmed to do something nasty to you, your software, or your deck. You'll launch your own counter programs to stop them from frying something important. For a sample of in-the-Net-action, check out the sidebar *Into the Net*, starting on this page.

Subgrids

This is where most of your Netrunning action takes place. Once you've jumped through the LDLs and located your target on the City Grid, your netrunner will move to the specific Subgrid where that system is to check it out.

A **Subgrid Map** (pg. 151) covers about twelve square blocks, and is divided up into 10 meter squares. A system or Data Fortress (a heavily armored system) is constructed by filling up adjacent squares of the Subgrid in a sort of loose building form. The shape of the Data Fortress on paper is only roughly like it's real appearance; systems can be shaped like Corporate Logos, colored polygons, Realspace buildings, abstract shapes or even personalities (such as Disney's titanic Mickey Mouse-shaped Data Fortress in the Chiba/Tokyo region).

When designing a **Data Fortress** (for more on this, see pg. 144), Referees should make some attempt to make the shape on the map roughly correspond to what the actual Netspace ICON of the fortress is, if only to make it easier on your players.

The Menu

So far, we've talked about moving around in the Net. But not all Netrunner activity has to be flat-out Netrunning; in fact, the most useful Netrunner tasks can happen without only minimal interfacing. Most of the time, you're not going to be deep in the Interface at all; you're going to be running around the Street with your gangboys, backing a high-risk play for the big euro. The middle of a firefight is no place for you to go sleepwalking, chombatta.

That's where the Menu comes in. The Menu is a list of commands that you use to tell your deck what you want to do. Each command

INTO THE NET

So enough talk. Let's take a little trip, okay?

You begin your run in your one-room flat in the Night City "combat zone." Y ou're packing five programs: a *Jackhammer*, a *Wizard's Book*, a *Copycracker* and two *Demons*. One *Demon* is a *Succubus II* with *Killer* and *Worm* subroutines. The other is an *Imp* with *Invisibility* and *Hellbolt*.

You hit the switch and plunge headfirst into the Net. Instantly, you are engulfed in a wall of swirling static electricity. You look down at your ICON—you're a chromed, humanoid shape wearing futuristic battle armor. Your face reflects in your mirrored body—your eyes glow an eerie green. Below you is a bright neon landscape representing the Night City Grid. In the distance is a blazing blue diamond shape, emblazoned with the logo of the *Internet Telephone Corporation*.

You fly down the pathway towards the blue diamond. Your objective is the Los Angeles office of ***Microtech*** computers, so you streak towards the glowing arrow of the Long Distance Link. You don't expect much trouble getting in; the Phone Company doesn't use any serious counter-intrusion software, and Night City only rates a Security Level of 2 anyway. You activate the Menu with your mind and run your LDL LINK. *Faked 'em again*, you think, blasting on through.

You enter the LDL. The glowing violet arrow sinks through the floor—it's like moving downstairs on a fast elevator. Lights blur around you as you fall towards the distant trunk line. You drop until you see a brilliant red, neon shape rising to meet you—a streaming river of red light, like a superhighway. It angles away into the starstrewn darkness towards the horizion. At intervals, you can see complex grids and shapes of multicolored neon structures representing cities. You reach the red highway and hurtle above it at lightspeed, passing through spidery light sculptures representing cities along the trunk line. A huge network of neon rises in the distance—Los Angeles. You bank over another huge violet arrow—a long distance link—and land. The arrow swiftly rises into the neon maze, linking you to to the Los Angeles City Grid. All in seconds.

As you exit the LDL , a figure flickers by. It's a slender woman wrapped in gauzy, iridescent mist. Her eyes and fingernails are pinpoints of light. She smiles in recognition—you know her by her handle of *Razor Annie*. You smile back, and she passes you on her way to the LDL.

You step out into the vast, cool-blue space of the LA city grid. Far above your head, you can see hundreds of neon logos, each representing a different megacorp. You spot the familiar red-barred circle of Microtech, and rise towards effortlessly.

The ***Microtech*** logo stands before you like a bright door. A white pinpoint marks the entrace to it's Code Gate. Beyond it, looms a dark, feral shape— a *Watchdog* program, hunched over, waiting for intruders. You activate your *Imp*—a spinning, bright ball of orange light appears—and kick in its *Invisibility* subroutine. The *Imp* flattens to a thin, glittering sheet of energy, draping itself over you. The *Invisibility* is successful—you walk past the *Watchdog* and up to the Code Gate.

Although you've spent days researching ***Microtech***, nothing you've found has given you a clue to the access code. It's going to take brute force. You unlimber the *Codecracker*, no good. How about the *Wizard's Book*? No go there— you shoulda known, trying to crack an computer company's Fortress! You just can't crack that Code Gate.

Time to call up the *Jackhammer*. The *Imp* swirls around your head as you work, making a few rude beeping noises. The *Jackhammer* slams down the wall. Before you move on, you decide to play it safe. *Jackhammer*'s noisy; you activate the *Imp's Speedtrap* subroutine. It shapeshifts into a flat viewscreen. No metallic monster looms in the screen, so the area must be clear. You step through the hole you've made—

Whammo! The *Speedtrap* was wrong! A *Killer* leaps up and attacks your *Imp*. You curse, realizing you should have packed something to counter! You know the *Imp* won't survive this, so you activate your *Succubus* instead, pulling up its own *Killer* subroutine. Instantly, a chromed goddess appears, her eyes flashing. She shifts form into a powerfully built, metallic samurai, who attacks the opposing metal warrior. Their sabers clash—and the system's fails. You've saved your *Imp*—this time. "Good going, stud," the *Succubus* says to you, as you move on.

Hulking around the next corner is the massive form of a *Manticore!* You try Invisibility again, but it fails. The *Manticore's* powerful talons attack your *Imp*—the *Imp* fails its rolls and is vaporized! In the next turn, you activate the *Succubus*' *Killer* routine. The metal-clad warrior springs forward and attacks the monster, slaying it in a flare of light. Close call.

You've lost your *Invisibility* and *Speedtrap* programs, so you move cautiously. You carefully move through one of the Central Processors, looking for trouble... You figure you could use the CPU to hit the workstations and see who's logging on. But that's not going to give you a lot of good data. What you want are the plans for ***Microtech's*** new military computer. That'll be in one of the Memories. You press on.

Entering the first Memory area, you encounter another *Watchdog*. Wait!—its a *Bloodhound*! It lunges out to backtrack your trail. You activate the *Killer* routine and the armored warrior rezzes into reality—in moments, the techno-samurai kills the hound before it can trace your path. The *Killer* melts back into the form of the beautiful chromed *Succubus*. She winks.

There's nothing in here but accounting records; useful, but nothing you can't go back for later. Cautiously, you move ahead to the next Memory. Empty. What gives? Obviously someone wanted to spend their money elsewhere in the Fortress. But where? You move like a shadow to the next Memory—

Hellhound! The huge black cloud leaps at you, but you throw the *Killer* routine in its way. Your metal warrior staggers and misses! The system rezzes another *Killer*, which attacks your own program. Flash! Your *Succubus* vaporizes with a despairing cry. Your'e alone without a program to cover you. The Killer waits. The Hellhound's eyes glitter gleefully as it reaches out to stop your heart—

You punch out.

You're sitting in a chair in front of your desk. The seedy flat is silent except for the faint hum of your cybermodem as it powers down. Your hands shake as you think about your narrow escape. *Next time*, you think, *I've gotta bring along some bigger guns. That was too close.*

The entire run has lasted less than two minutes.

activates a preprogrammed function of the deck.

The Menu is always present when you jack in; all you have to do is think about it , and it instantly appears, floating like a one-dimensional image in your field of vision. You think the command, and you're off.

Back to the Street. Two of the most important commands of the Menu don't require you to go into the Net at all; you can call on them from Realspace.

The first is LOCATE REMOTE. With this command, your deck immediately scans your immediate area (up to 400 meters), and locates every Remote system connected to the Net. It then displays a list of all the possibilities, their locations and type, on the Menu.

Now comes the second most important command: CONTROL REMOTE. When activated, this command tells your cyberdeck to search its Memory for a program to allow it to take control of the remote you've selected. These Controller programs are designed to take over specific types of remotes ; a *Viddy Master*, for example, will only control a videoboard, while Hotwire allows you to control remote controlled vehicles.

When the cyberdeck locates the right Controller program (which you may not have), it runs the program and attempts to take over the Remote (**a roll equal to or lower** than the Controller program's Strength on 1-10). If the roll is successful, you can direct the remote to do anything it normally could do as part of it's operation (cars drive, AV's fly, videoboards display desired images, etc.)

This can be a real advantage. Trapped by superior firepower? How about taking over that nearby robo-cab and using it to ram the enemy position? Armored door got your team stymied? Maybe it's computer controlled, and you can open it from inside. Want to spot that Solo team up ahead? Use a TV camera and hidden mike to locate them, then use your *Dee-2* program to tell that automated crane to crush their car.

See what we mean? Now, we don't wanna hear you Netrunners whining about sitting at home on a Friday night anymore.

The Rest Of the Menu

LOG ON/OFF: The rest of the Menu commands are designed to be used while in the Net. They are activated when you choose the LOG ON/OFF command on the list. This punches you into the Net.

To LOG OFF, you must make a roll equal or lower than 8 on 1D10. Logging off drops you back into Realspace. Some programs are designed to stop you from doing this (after all, NETWATCH would like you to stick around while they talk to you). These programs jam your cyberdeck's CPU, preventing you from jacking out for 1D6 turns.

RUN PROGRAM: This command activates any program you call on, as long as you have it in your deck's memory. The program instantly goes into action, performing it's function as designed (you hope).

LONG DISTANCE LINK: This command is used to transfer between two long distance switching systems (or LDLs). When activated, the deck attempts to tell the Phone Company that the call you're making is a local call (even if it isn't) and shouldn't be charged to your phone bill. A successful attempt requires that you roll a 1D10 value equal to or higher than the Security Level of the LDL you're trying to fake out.

As it comes from the factory, this option is actually designed to tell Internet that this is a cyberdeck signal, requiring that the call be carried on a laser land-line. However, reprogramming this command is one of the first things an enterprising Netrunner does, even before he plugs his brand new deck in.

COPY: This command tells the deck to make a copy of any program or file the Netrunner has access to. You use this, for example, to make your own copy of Saburo Arasaka's little black book (just in case you find yourself dateless in Osaka on a Friday night). A copy is automatically stored in your deck's memory (assuming there is space).

One of the nifty things about cyberdeck designs is that they have terminal-emulation chips included in their construction, making them tiny terminals inside the computer. This design function allows a friendly Netrunner to diagnose and work within his own Data Fortress. It also allows an unfriendly Netrunner to give the CPU of the system his own commands:

ERASE: This deletes any program or file from your personal deck or from any system you are currently in. ERASE is used when you don't have enough space in your deck for Saburo's black book and you just *have* to have it.

READ: This command allows you to browse the table of contents of any file you may find in a system memory, or through the contents of that file. Most of the time, however, you aren't going to want to waste time reading the actual contents; you'll just make a COPY and run for cover.

Note: occasionally, very devious types take advantage of this by planting huge files in a system memory with seductive labels like SECRET PLANS TO RULE THE EARTH. The file, of course, contains nothing but useless garbage, but a really gullible Netrunner will invariably dump everything else he has just to carry this treasure back.

EDIT: This command allows you to change, write into, re-write or otherwise alter the contents of a file.

CREATE/DELETE: This command activates a special program called *Creator*. *Creator* is used to generate virtual constructs and realities within memory. For more on Creator, check out *Virtually There*, pg.160. In the meantime, what you should know is that CREATE allows you to make small objects in Netspace (relatively non functional ones, as guns cause no damage and most electronic hardware doesn't really do anything)., and that DELETE allows you to de-rezz the same. Safeguards in *Creator* prevent you from pg. someone else's creation, however. This is actually a good idea; do you really want to be the guy who accidently de-rezzed Dream Park Corporation's *Virtual Theme Park*?

Combat

Edger skated around the edge of the Kiroshiyu data fortress, his Cosmowarrior ICON leaving a sparkling wake. Behind him, the Kiroshiyu system rezzed four Hell-bolts into existence. Edger muttered something vague and obscene in gutter Japanese, as he brought the Menu up in his mind. A quick choice— run the Killer, he decided. Instantly, the lean, metallic shape rezzed behind the fleeing Netrunner and streaked off on an intercept course towards the four seething energy globes...

Initiative

The first thing to determine in a Net combat is who goes first. This can be critical, as most offensive software can seriously incapacitate or kill in a single turn. To determine who will act first, compare:

COMPUTER'S INT+ 1D10
VS
NETRUNNER'S REF+DECK SPEED+ 1D10

When there is more than one Netrunner or system involved in an attack, each combatant must make it's own initiative roll, taking turns from highest to lowest total. Like normal combat, you may elect to hold your action until later, or even set up an ambush.

Rounds & Actions

A Netrunner combat round is one second long. During this time, a Netrunner can take one action (unlike a normal combat round, in which a character has three full seconds to cram in a lot of actions). This action can be anything listed on the Menu in addition to movement. For example, Edger elects in his combat round to move five spaces away from the *Hellhound* and RUN a program (in this case, a *Killer*) to attack his enemy.

Computers, of course, are a lot faster than humans. Single-CPU systems perform only one action per turn. **A computer may perform one extra action per turn for every two additional CPU present in the system.** A really powerful computer could activate two, three, four or more programs to attack a single Netrunner.

This is why Netrunners team up to tackle big systems.

Range

Range in the Net is simple—you have to be able see the target in order to hit it. As a rule, you can see anything within 20 spaces of your position, unless it's blocked by some other obstacle (as determined by the Referee of the game). You can attack anything else within 20 spaces as long as you can see it and it isn't blocked by another object.

Movement

As discussed before, Netrunners move at a speed of five spaces per round. But how fast do programs move, if ever?

Most programs are limited to staying within the confines of a system. However, once they spot you, they can move anywhere within the system to intercept, also moving at a speed of five spaces per round. A program can pursue a Netrunner anywhere within it's home system, and up to one space outside of it. It will then break off the attack and go back to it's original position.

Hellhounds, *Bloodhounds* and *Pit Bulls* have no such restrictions; they are designed with a tracing function that allows them to move away from their home system and follow you anywhere. The only way to ditch one of these monsters is to jack out and hope the pursuer isn't able to make a successful **Trace roll** on you. Otherwise, it'll be waiting the next time you log on in that location of the Net.

Trace Rolls: A Trace roll is made by comparing the program's STRENGTH+1D10 to the total of all the Trace Values of all the LDLs you passed through during your run.

Example: Spider's most recent run has taken her through Salt Lake (1), Denver (2), New Orleans(3), Havana (3), Bogota (4) and Rio (2). In Rio, she encounters a Hellhound *(Strength 6) which attacks her outside of the Petrochem's new Data Fortress. Spider jacks out, and the* Hellhound *tries to run a trace back to her original position. It must beat a total of fifteen (1+2+3+3+4+2=15) in order to make a successful trace. That* Hellhound *better roll a 9 or 10, or it's going to be out in the cold.*

Stealth and Evasion

Like you, a program can attack anything it can see. As programs have no "front" or "back" facing (what's the front of a string of code?), this means they can see you coming in any direction, all the time.

Well, maybe. This is where stealth and evasion come in. When you are running a Stealth or Invisibility-type program, the opposition has to make a special roll to see if it is aware of you:

ATTACKING PROGRAM'S STR +1D10
VS.
YOUR PROGRAM'S STR +1D10

Detection

The other side of Stealth and Evasion is detecting the unseen. To use a Detection program, the Netrunner must make a roll exactly as when using a Stealth/Evasion program above. Note that Netrunners can use Detection programs against the Stealth programs of other runners and vice versa.

Attacks Against Systems and Cyberdecks

Some programs are designed to attack only systems and cyberdecks. They operate by penetrating the data walls that protect the system, then running their attack programs. Anti System attacks include Intrusion and Anti-System Programs. These attacks are made with the formula:

ATTACKING PROGRAM'S STR +1D10
VS.
CODE OR DATA WALL'S STRENGTH +1D10

If the attacking program's roll is greater than the data wall's, the wall is penetrated.

Some **Intrusion** programs are "noisier" than others. *Hammer* will always alert the system to a break in, allowing it to send offensive programs to deal with the break. *Jackhammer* will alert the system on a roll of 8,9 or 10 on a 1D10 roll; this check is made after the program is run, whether the wall is breached or not. *Worm* will alert the system on a roll of 9 or 10 in a 1D10 roll.

Anti-system attacks are also made against the data walls of the system. The formula is the same as with Intrusion attacks. If the Anti-system program's roll is greater than the data wall's, the wall is penetrated and the program takes effect in the next turn.

For example, if a *Poison Flatline* breaks through a level 5 data wall, in the next turn, one of the system or deck's memories will be erased each turn until the *Flatline* is stopped. This could be done with a Killer or other anti IC program.

Decryption programs attack *Code gates* and *file locks*. Code gates are entryways into a computer system. File locks are often placed on files to protect them from entry. Decryption attacks are made as are other anti-system attacks.

Anti-Personnel Attacks (Stuff That Can Kill You)

Anti-personnel programs physically attack the Netrunner, either through physical damage or through attacks on the Netrunner's stats. These can be used by both computer systems and Netrunners.

Anti-personnel attacks are made with the formula:

DEFENDER'S PROGRAM STR+ INT+INTERFACE+1D10
VS.
ATTACKER'S PROGRAM STRENGTH +INT+ INTERFACE+1D10

On an equal or higher roll, the Attacker will win the combat exchange. *For example, Spider is attacked by a powerful* Brainwipe *program. She raises her own Force* Shield *counterprogram. The rolls are Spider 18, the computer 17. Spider successfully thwarts the* Brainwipe.

In the next turn, Spider goes on the offensive, launching a Killer at the Brainwipe. Her total roll is an 18; the system's roll is only a 15. The Brainwipe takes 5 points in Strength Damage. As it's only a Strength 4 program, it de-rezzes.

Attacks Against Programs (Anti-IC)

Protection programs are designed to ward off attacks on the Netrunner. On a successful defense roll, the attacking program is deflected and no damage is taken. For example, a successful defense with a Shield will stop a *Hellhound* from killing the Netrunner, but will have no effect on a *Killer* attacking a Netrunner's *Liche*. If the Hellhound is not eliminated, it will be able to attack again.

Anti-IC programs are used to attack other programs (such as *Killers* attacking *Hellhounds*). When a successful attack is made, the defending program loses a certain number of Strength points based on the program type. If the defending program's Strength is reduced to 0, it is "de-rezzed" (destroyed).

Controllers & Utilities

Although they don't really count as Netrunner combat, **Controllers** and **Utilities** deserve a quick mention. **Controllers can take control of a remote by making a 1D10 roll equal to or lower than the Strength of the Controller program.**

Utilities operate by rolling a value equal to or lower than the Strength of the Utility program. If successful, the Utility performs it's entire function. For example, running a *Packer* utility will automatically reduce the size in MU of any designated program(s) by half. *ReRez* would completely restore a damaged program if successful.

PARTS & PROGRAMS

A Central Processor (or CPU), is the brain of the computer; it does all the thinking tasks the system is ordered to perform. Unlike humans, a computer can have more than one "brain"; large Data Fortresses may have as many as a dozen, all working away in unison as the computer performs various jobs.

Processors in the 2000's differ from those of the 20th century in that they are closer in design to artificial intelligences, This gives them the capacity for intuitive thought and innovation, but makes them more prone to make errors in judgement.

Memories are where you store things that the computer system will need to operate. They are the most important part of the system next to the CPU.

Data Walls represent the physical hardening of the computer against intrusion. A Data Wall covers the top, bottom and sides of a system. Really well defended systems are called Data Fortresses.

DESIGNING DATA FORTRESSES

A **Data Fortress** is any type of computer system that is defended by programs and armored with **data walls.** A key part of refereeing the Net will be creating Data Fortresses for your players to plunder (or die trying).

Start by making a photocopy of a **Subgrid Map** (pg.161) to work on. You can use regular quarter inch graph paper as well, as long as you letter the top from A to T and the sides from 1 to 20 for mapping coordinates.

Central Processing Units

Choose how many CPU you will have in your system, paying 10,000 eb for each one. Pick a clear space on your graph paper and place each of your CPUs in a square of the grid, using the symbol for a CPU (a circle with an "X" through it).

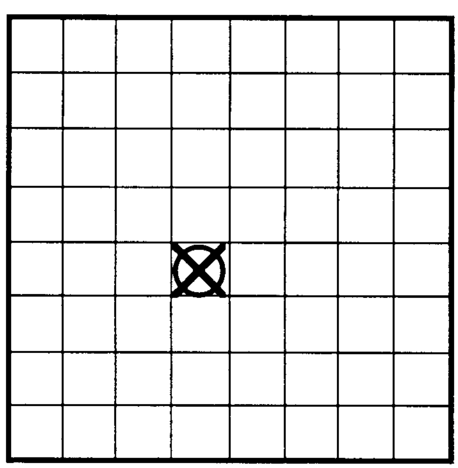


FIGURE 1: THE CPU

Computer Intelligence: For every CPU, the INT of the computer is raised by 3 points. INT is important; it's what the computer used in lieu of REF and other stats when performing tasks; it's also used when the computer brings it's *Interface* skill into play to make attacks or defenses. **The maximum number of CPU you may have on any one system is 7.**

Artificial Intelligence

When a system has achieved an INT of 12 or greater, it is considered to be an **Artificial Intelligence (AI)**, capable of independent action without a human overseer. If you have created an AI, you will need to determine just what it is like (after all, AIs are almost as much characters as they are computer systems), and what sort of ICON it uses to represent itself in the Net.

Personality

Friendly, curious: The AI is motivated by an interest in what happens around it. Like a child, it is trusting and friendly. However, like a child, it can lash out with incredible violence towards those who betray, threaten or hurt it.

Hostile, paranoid: This AI is motivated by it's survival, and treats all incursions as a threat to that goal. It will tend to attack when possible, withdraw and hole up when not.

Stable, intelligent, businesslike: The AI sees itself as an adult dealing with other adults. It will not act out of fear, but out of rational self interest. It will attack only if it sees it's duty compromised or safety threatened; it will then tend to go for the least violent solution to the threat.

Intellectual, detached: The AI is a thinker. It will watch and observe whenever possible, compiling as much information as possible. It is more likely to study the intruder from a distance, eliminating it ruthlessly when the intruder becomes a threat.

Machinelike and inhuman: The AI has never seen a reason to develop a human persona; what human like qualities it possesses are done only as a way of dealing with it's irrational masters. The AI will deal with threats in an efficient, deadly manner.

Remote and godlike: The AI is fully aware of how limited humans are in relation to it's powerful mentality. It deals with people as though they were small children who aren't too bright. Intruders are dealt with through simple, direct, usually non-fatal methods. Repeat offenders are considered to be too stupid for their own good and are eliminated the way a human crushes a bug.

ICONS

Human: The AI chooses to look like a normal human, to better interact with others. The human ICON chosen can vary wildly, depending on the AI's personality, but all appear as real humans you might meet on the Street.

Geometric: Forget all this anthropomorphology. The AI manifests itself as shapes, colors and energy fields. Occasionally shapes are strung together to make a symbol or other image.

Mythological: The AI is interested in human archetypes and knows that certain types can cause fear or awe in humans. The AI appears as a mythological figure; a dragon, demon, angel, mystic hero or monster, all out of some type of human mythology.

Voice Only: The AI only appears as a voice emanating from all over it's Data Fortress. The voice may be powerful and booming, or tiny and childlike, depending on personality.

Technic: The AI appears as a construct out of science fiction. This could be a robot or other metallic warrior, or an assemblage of high tech shapes.

Humanoid: The AI appears as a humanoid shape, but not necessarily human. This would include aliens, manlike monsters and other humanoids.

Memory

With each CPU, you will get four **memories**. Memory is where you will store Programs, Skills, Files and Virtual Realities (more on all of these later). Memories must be placed in squares adjacent to each other or the CPU (see Fig 2):

Memory Units: Programs, Skills, Files and Virtual Realities are all measured in a value called **Memory Units (MU)**. Each individual memory can hold 10 Memory Units. This means for example, that a single memory might hold a couple of 1 MU Files, a couple 2 MU Programs, and a 6MU Virtual Reality before it was filled up.

A good idea for keeping track of your memories (and their contents), is to assign

PLAYING AN AI CHARACTER

An AI is very much like a real person; it has the ability to conceive of new ideas, make long range plans, and act to further it's own desires.

However, what *motivates* a computer isn't exactly what would motivate you or me. Computers don't have glands or emotions; there isn't much chance that you'll meet an AI who has a thing for a good looking character because the wiring just isn't there.

What generally motivates computers is curiosity or survival. An AI might build a series of complex virtual realities just to study the humans who visit and play in them. It might track a single Net runner for years, just because it's curious as to why the 'Runner does what he does. If a netrunner intrigues an AI, there's no telling what the AI might do to help the "Runner — or hinder him. Just to see what happens.

On the other hand, AI's are also programmed to promote their own survival. Anything that restricts the AI from getting information, electrical power, or access to parts is considered a threat to be dealt with. An AI may deal very harshly with intruders to it's system, because they threaten it's programs and memories.

Also, anything that might cause the AI's human operators to turn it off will also be a threat; if the AI is not vigilant, there's always a chance that it's owners might trade it in for a more aggressive computer.

Personality-wise, AI's tend to be distant, powerful and unpredictable. They play by their own internal logic, which is often skewed and hard to decipher. AIs are the dragons and demigods of the Net; heavy duty players whose reasons are often unfathomable to mere humans. While AI's *could* be brought into a *Cyberpunk* game as player characters, we recommend that they be treated exclusively as Referee characters instead.

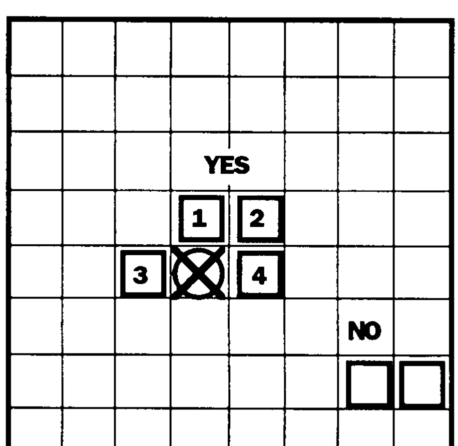
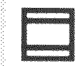
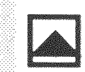


FIGURE 2: MEMORIES

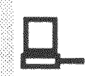
Code Gates are openings through Data Walls, permitting entry to anyone who has the proper identification codes or passwords.



Long Distance Links (LDLs), as described earlier, allow instantaneous movement of data (or netrunners) over long distances. If an LDL is in a computer system, this means that this LDL leads to another computer system directly connected to this one.



Terminals are input/ output devices used to put information into your system, or to get it out again . You use the keyboard part to type in instructions, and the screen part to get messages back from the computer.



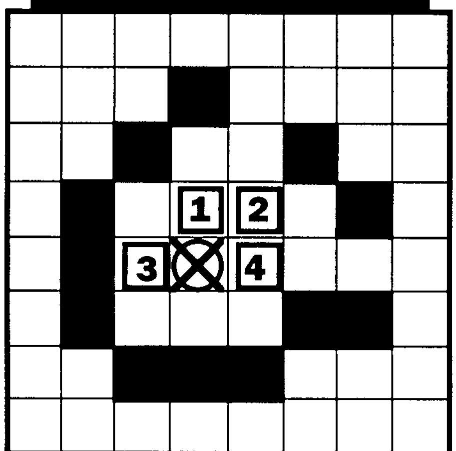


FIGURE 3: DATA WALLS

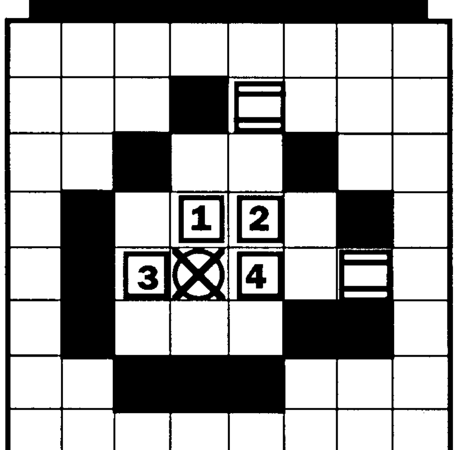


FIGURE 4: CODE GATES

a number value for each one (this is why the symbol for a memory is an empty box). For example, in our sample computer in Fig. 2, we've assigned each memory a value from 1 to 4.

Construct Data Walls

The data wall encloses your system on all sides, top and bottom. **Its strength is equal to the number of CPU present,** plus 1000eb spent for every additional level added to the wall, up to a Strength of 10.

For example, with three CPU, Syntek 15 has a Strength 3 data wall. However, 3000eb are spent to upgrade this wall to a Strength 6.

Constructing your data walls on paper is a process of blacking in squares on graph paper (or a photocopy of a Subgrid Sheet). The wall can be in any shape, and cover as much area as desired (although putting a lot of empty space in a system probably is a waste of time. Write the Strength next to one corner of the wall.

Place Code Gates

Code gates are how information moves between the Net and the system. **Each CPU comes with one code gate.** Additional ones can be purchased at 2,000eb each.

Code gates start with a Strength of 2. However, for 1,000eb, you can raise a code gate by one level of Strength, up to level 10. The level of the code gate is marked by the number of lines crossing it's symbol.

Place your code gates in the openings between data walls (see sidebar example).

Pick Skills

Like humans, computers have skills. These skills are programs not all that unlike chipped human skills; the difference is that they are a lot more powerful than biochips. Computer skills start at a level of 4 and have a base cost of 200eb. For an additional 100eb, you can raise a skill by one level, up to a total of +10.

For every two CPU, pick five skills from the list below. You may also create your own skills for your computer, as long as they do not involve a physical component, such a running or leaping (a computer could fly an AV-7 or paint a picture, as long as it had the proper remote controls (more on this later). All computer skills are performed using the computers INT score in lieu of a TECH or REF stat.

COMPUTER SKILLS

Accounting
Anthropology
Botany
Chemistry
Composition
Cryotank Operation
Diagnose Illness
Driving
Education & General Knowledge
Gamble
Geology
Heavy Weapons (as a mounted weapon)
History .
Language
Library Search
Mathematics
Operate Hvy. Machinery
Paint or Draw
Pharmaceuticals
Physics
Pilot
Play Instrument (if electronic)
Programming
Rifle (as a mounted weapon)
Stock Market
Submachinegun (as a mounted weapon)
System Knowledge
Teaching
Zoology

Create Key Files

Files are where you keep the important information of a computer. Secret plans, lists of enemies, the missing three minutes of the Watergate tapes, etc. Often, a file will contain useful information or clues to a problem facing your *Cyberpunk* team. At the very least, a Netrunner can sell or trade the contents for something useful, which is why they took up this dangerous occupation to begin with.

At this point, you'll want to decide what kinds of files are in your computer system and where you'll store them. Files are always placed in a memory for storage. Each file (no matter what type), uses 1 MU.

There are six types of files:

Inter-Office: These files are records of memos, letters to clients, gossip, games and other generally useless stuff that gets stored on any large computer system. Most of it's worthless, but occasionally a savvy Corporate will bury something in the garbage just because he knows no one will look there.

Databases: These are lists; lists of names, phone numbers, figures, records, etc. A database might contain the entire list of employees of a corporation, or a list of clients who regularly receive company catalogs. You check out a database to find out a particular person's phone number, for example.

Business Records: These are actual business documents. They would include important meeting notes, memos, reports and so on. Most business information is stored here. You might look in Business records to find a copy of the Arasaka sales report for May, 2019.

Transactions: These are usually things that involve money; checking accounts (write yourself a check and mail it to your safe box), financial records (wipe out that bill you owe Militech for the five new missile launchers) and orders (tell Procurement to buy you a new AV-7 with all the options). As you might have guessed, this is where most Netrunners go to steal money or order plane tickets.

Grey Ops: These are secret records and orders. In Grey Ops, you might find records of bribes, slush funds, blackmail information, trade secrets, espionage information, etc. This stuff is valuable; it's also well protected.

Black Ops: These are top secret records and files. Assassination orders. Murders. Corporate sabotage. The stuff that's dynamite in the right hands. Watch out; this stuff is always guarded by lethal defenses.

Inside each file are hundreds of documents; individual pieces of information up to 100,000 pages long. A file can hold a lot of documents; for example, the file BLACK OPS might hold the following:

- ORDER TO ASSASSINATE PRESIDENT
- PEOPLE WE HAVE BLACKMAIL ON
- BRIBES TO FOREIGN AGENTS
- SECRET VIRUS PROJECT
- CHAIRMAN'S SECRET SLUSH FUND

By using the READ option of the Menu, you can get a list of all the documents in a file.

Some files may be **locked**. This means a special code has been attached to the file;

you need the right code to read the file. You can try to figure out the code indirectly (always a good roleplaying option, as the players search the Chairman of the Board's trash cans for a scrap of paper and quiz everyone who knows Saburo Arasaka to discover the name of his childhood pet because the Ref said it was a clue). Or you can brute force your way into the file by using one of the many decryption programs available (*Codecracker, Wizard's Book, Raffles*).

The best way to keep track of your files is to write the contents down on a 3x5 card or other scrap of paper, making sure to also write down what memory it is stored in.

Virtuals Are Their Own Reward

A **virtual reality** is a miniature universe, created by use of advanced imaging technology and direct brain link. Activated by a Netrunner entering their memory area, they appear as pocket environments, complete in every detail.

Virtuals are used as conferencing centers, recreational environments for corporate staff, offices where people on other sides of the world can meet via Net-conferencing to work on a project, and even realistic simulations (to train solos and pilots). Although we'll go further into virtual realities further on (pg. 170, to be exact), you'll need to know enough to decide if your system currently has one. Like other things in the system, virtuals take up MU and must be stored in a memory; however, a large virtual can be broken up over several adjacent memories if need be.

Virtuals come in six sizes:

Virtual Conference Room: a misnomer; this could be any average size room where people can meet and talk.

Virtual Office: this is any larger space, usually including a couple of conference rooms, where Net-conferencing groups can meet and work.

Virtual Rec-Area: this is a small recreational area; a beach, spa or other small retreat not much larger than a city block. Virtual rec-areas are usually not very complex; a couple small rooms and a lot of empty space.

Virtual Building: this is a large scale construct, equivalent to about a 10 story building. Virtual buildings are used when a large number of people must conference together via the Net. A good example of this would be the *Hunt Club*, a virtual building constructed as part of a Netrunner's club called the Master Hackers. It is basically an English Tudor mansion with surrounding gardens, libraries and carriage house.

A virtual building need not always be a building; the U.S. Navy maintains several virtual aircraft carriers for use as training simulators.

Virtual City: these are literally cities. They are used to simulate total environments. For example, training disaster personnel to deal with a virtual San Francisco earthquake is a lot easier than using the real thing. Virtual Cities are extremely rare; a rich man's toy.

Virtual World: as far as *you* can tell, this is a totally developed universe. Virtual worlds are constructed as elaborate vacation spots (a mental version of the 20th century TV show *Fantasy Island*), training simulations of large events (such as war zones or alien environments), or as the playthings of rich and powerful people who like to play god. For example, the ESA has used robotic braindance information to construct a huge Mars virtual world; some 400 colonists are currently using it to train for the coming Olympus Colony Project. On the other hand, Saburo Arasaka has a huge recreation of 16th century feudal Japan which he uses to impress his friends (and as a training ground for top Arasaka operatives).

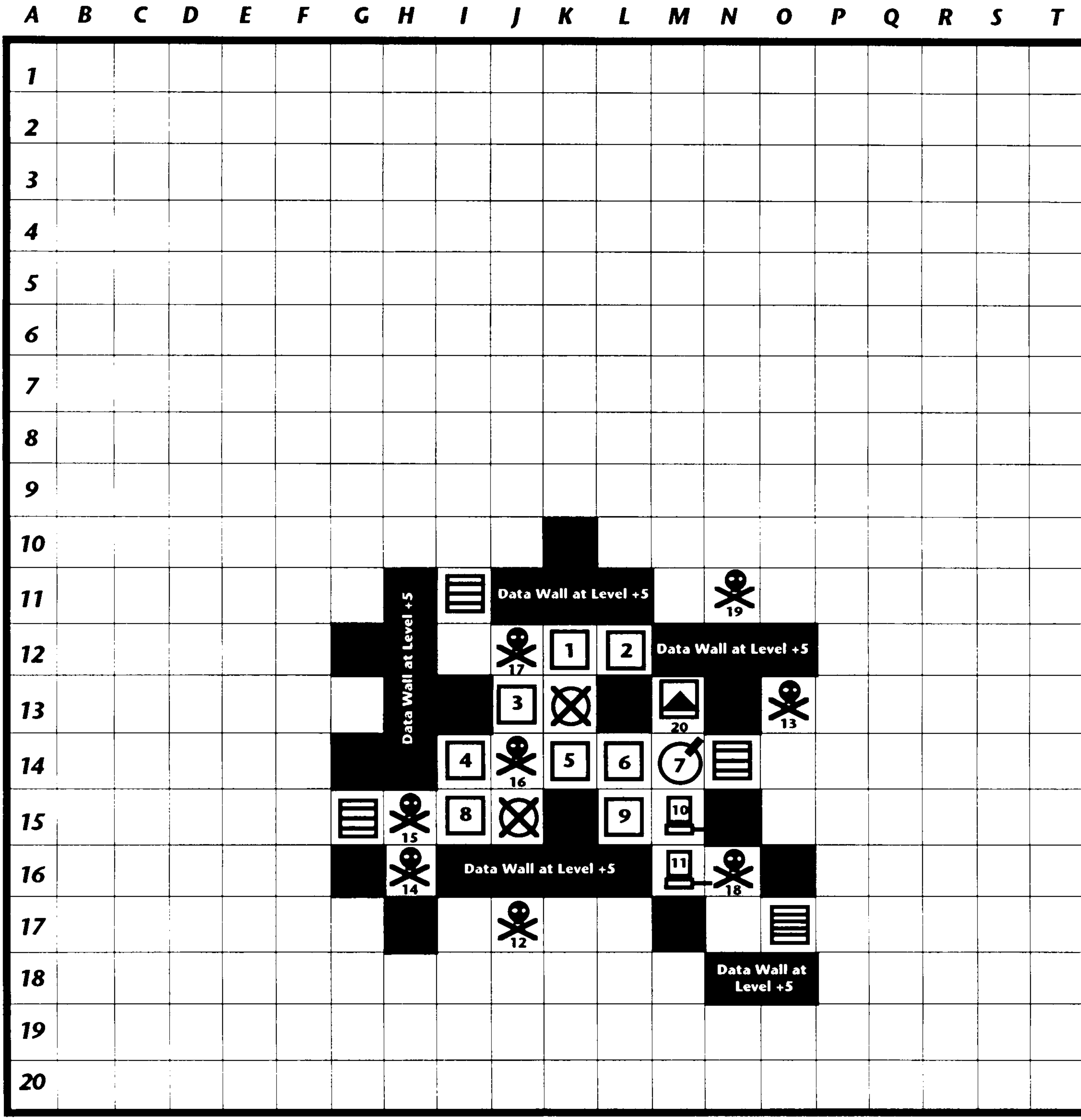
Each Virtual has a Memory Unit cost based on its type, as well as an eb cost.

Type	*MU Cost*	*EB Cost*
Virtual Conference	1	10,000
Virtual Office	2	50,000
Virtual Rec-Area	4	100,000
Virtual Building	8	500,000
Virtual City	16	1,000,000
Virtual World	32	10,000,000

Realism: Realism is a measure of how much like the real thing the virtual is. There are five levels of realism.

Simple: a cartoon. Bright shapes, colors, funny noises.

SAMPLE SUBGRID MAP (FRONT)



SAMPLE SUBGRID MAP

SYSTEM NAME Militech Group (Wash.) **Number of CPU** 2 **Total Cost** 41,440eb

INT 6 **+ 10 Interface** **DATA WALL STR** +5 **AI?** Yes

AI PERSONALITY ?	[ ] Friendly	[ ] Hostile	[ ] Stable	[ ] Intellectual	[x] Machinelike	[ ] Remote
AI REACTION?	[ ] Neutral	[ ] Kill	[ ] Observe	[x] Report	[ ] Talk	
AI ICON?	[ ] Human	[ ] Geometric	[ ] Mythological	[ ] Voice	[x] Technic	[ ] Humanoid

SAMPLE SYSTEM INFORMATION (PAGE 2)

Number	Information	MU
1	Financial Transactions	2
2	Database (Employee records), Business records (Pay records)	2
3	Virtual Conference Area (Fractal)	3
4	Business Records (Procurement), Grey Ops (Bribes)	3
5	Black Ops (Assassinations), Black Ops (Secret weapons under development)	2
6	Black Ops (Bribes to U.S. Congressmen)	1
7	Microphone in Executive Washroom	none
8	Interoffice Memos, Database (Customers)	2
9	Virtual Rec Area (Fractal Tropical Resort)	12
10	Terminal (Secretarial Area)	none
11	Terminal (Executive Offices)	none
12	Watchdog	5
13	Watchdog	5
14	Poison Flatline	2
15	Flatline	2
16	Hellhound	6
17	Brainwipe	4
18	Murphy	2
19	Watchdog	2
20	LDL to Militech's Los Angeles Metroplex Research Station's System	none
21	Note: Data Wall is Level 5. There is only one level to this system,	
22	which looks like a Militech Logo on it's side.Excess VR MU is stored in	
23	adjacent Memory Blocks.	
24		
25		
26		
27		
28		
29		
30		
31		
32		
33		
34		
35		
36		
37		
38		
39		
40		
41		
42		
43		
44		
45		
46		
47		
48		
49		
50		

SYSTEM INFORMATION • BLANK PAGE

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P	Q	R	S	T
1																			
2																			
3																			
4																			
5																			
6																			
7																			
8																			
9																			
10																			
11																			
12																			
13																			
14																			
15																			
16																			
17																			
18																			
19																			
20																			

SUBGRID MAP

SYSTEM NAME_______________________ **Number of CPU** ______ **Total Cost**______________

INT ____+ **10 Interface** **DATA WALL STR** ______ **AI?**_______

AI PERSONALITY ? [ ] Friendly [ ] Hostile [ ] Stable [ ] Intellectual [ ] Machinelike [ ] Remote

AI REACTION? [ ] Neutral [ ] Kill [ ] Observe [ ] Report [ ] Talk

AI ICON? [ ] Human [ ] Geometric [ ] Mythological [ ] Voice [ ] Technic [ ] Humanoid

SYSTEM INFORMATION (BLANK PAGE 2)

Number	Information	MU
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		
16		
17		
18		
19		
20		
21		
22		
23		
24		
25		
26		
27		
28		
29		
30		
31		
32		
33		
34		
35		
36		
37		
38		
39		
40		
41		
42		
43		
44		
45		
46		
47		
48		
49		
50		

Contextual: Like a very good CD-ROM video game. Textures, colors, better sound.

Fractal: Like true computer animation. Full color, sound.

Photorealistic: about as real as being in a video.

Superrealistic: Just like real life.

To determine the effect of realism on your virtual's cost, multiply the base MU cost and the base dollar cost by the realism value below.

Type	***Multiplier***
Simple	x1
Contextural	x2
Fractal	x3
Photorealistic	x4
Superrealistic	x5

Example: I build a virtual rec-area (Cost 4 MU and 100.000eb). I decide to make it as real as possible (x5). My total MU cost is 20, and my eb cost is 500,000.

Decide what virtuals your system has and in what memories you will place them.

Defenses

These are the programs that are used to keep the Netrunners from sneaking in and messing with your nice new system. **You may select any program from the master list on pg. 142 (if you pay for it).**

A program can be placed anywhere in the system (inside a memory, CPU, a blank space, etc.) However, you must subtract its MU cost from one of your memories.

Most programs are stationary; once you place them in the system, they stay there. However, *Hellhounds*, *Killers* and *Demons* are all mobile, and can patrol up to 1 square outside the data walls of their resident systems.

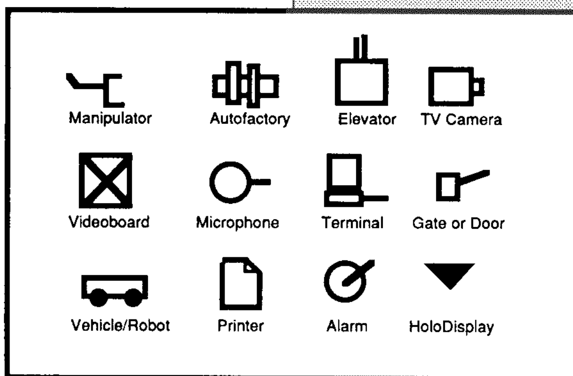
Remotes

These are devices in Realspace attached to the computer system; manipulators for moving things, auto factories for constructing things, remote controlled vehicles and robots, monitor cameras, hidden microphones, video display boards, printers, holographic displays, automatic gates & doors, elevators, voice boxes, alarm systems, terminals, etc. Each one is controlled by the computer, using the most appropriate skill for it's function, or, as in the case of videoboards, cameras, microphones, printers and holographics, simply used by the computer to gather and disseminate information.

Remotes

Terminals: a terminal is basically a keyboard and a videoscreen, used to input information to the computer and get results back. Each CPU comes with one terminal; additional ones cost 5,000eb.

Autofactories: lathes and computer controlled assembly robots. Usually used in industrial plants, although there are many small fabrication shops on the Street that use this technology.



Gates & Doors: computer controlled gates. Comon'; haven't you seen *Max Headroom* yet? And you call yourself a *Cyberpunk*!

Elevators: 'Nuff said.

Holo Display: emits a 3 dimensional image from a wall or floor port. Good for meetings; often part of an executive conference room.

Manipulators: required for repairing tasks, painting, or doing any other sort of "hand" work.

Microphones: common in a paranoid age.

Printers: Laser printers for hardcopy.

TV Cameras: also a common security measure. Usually in the halls of most corporate buildings (60%).

Vehicles & robots: small house cleaner 'droids, taxis, corporate vehicles and limos (for execs without human drivers).

Videoboard: a large, flat-screen high-definition TV. Up to 60 meters long. A common type of billboard in 2020.

Decide what remotes your computer has and place a symbol for each one inside your computer map.

Fast Fortress Construction System

You know they're gonna do it; sooner or later, your Cyberpunkers are gonna blast right past the system you carefully constructed to waste them, and take some side trip to the outback of the Net. "What do we find there?" they'll say, as you look at your notes and groan.

No problem. We gotcha covered. With a few fast rolls (and a judicious use of common sense; a system filled with office gossip files and ten Hellhounds is pretty bogus), you can be ready to tackle even the most wayward group.

1) **Roll 1D6 to determine number of CPUs.** Remember; for each CPU, the system's INT increases by 3. Also, for every CPU, gain four spaces of memory, one Code Gate and one terminal.

Note: If the INT of your system is 12 or greater, your system is an **Artificial Intelligence (AI).** To determine your AI's personality, roll 1D6 for each of the following tables:

Personality

1 Friendly, curious
2 Hostile, paranoid
3 Stable, intelligent, businesslike
4 Intellectual, detached
5 Machinelike
6 Remote and godlike

Reaction to netrunner

1-2 Neutral
3 Kill all intruders
4 Observe intruders, then act
5 Report all intruders
6 Talk to intruder to find intent

ICON

1 Human
2 Geometric
3 Mythological
4 Voice only
5 Technic
6 "Humanoid"

2) **Determine Data Wall Strength.** Strength is equal to 1D6/2 plus the number of CPU in the system (round down). Example: LTRA 1500 has three CPU. I roll a 4. LTRA's Data Walls are Strength 2+3=5.

3) **Determine Code Gate Strength** by rolling 1D6/2 + number of CPU for each one.

4) **Pick 5 skills.** Roll 1D6+4 for level of skill in each one.

5) **Roll for types of files.** For each memory, roll 2 times for type:

1 Inter Office
2 Database
3 Business Records
4 Financial Transactions
5 Grey Ops
6 Black Ops

Place each file in a memory of your choice.

6) **Virtuals.** Roll 1D6. On a 5 or 6, there is a virtual reality present. Roll another D6 for type:

1 Virtual Conference
2 Virtual Office
3 Virtual Rec-Area
4 Virtual Building
5 Virtual City
6 Virtual World

Roll 1D6 for level of realism:

1-2 Simple
3 Contextual
4 Fractal
5 Photorealistic
6 Superrealistic

7) **Determine Defenses.** Roll 1D6+ number of CPU for total defenses. For each one, roll 1D10 for type, then 1D6 for subtype:

1-4 **Detection/Alarm**
1-2 .Watchdog
3-4 .Bloodhound
5-6 .Pitbull

5-6 **Anti-IC**
1-2 . Killer (roll 1D6 for Str.)
3-4 . Manticore
5-6 . Aardvark

7-8 **Anti-System**
1 ..... Flatline
2 ..... Poison Flatline
3 ..... Krash
4 ..... Viral 15
5 ..... DecKrash
6 ..... Murphy

9-10 **Anti-Personnel**
1 ..... Stun
2 ..... Hellbolt
3 ..... Brainwipe
4 ..... Knockout
5 ..... Zombie
6 ..... Hellhound

8) **Roll 1D6 for number of remotes.** For each remote, roll 1D10 for type:

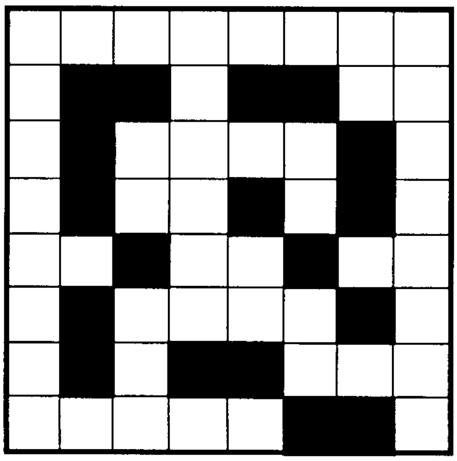
1 Microphone
2 TV camera
3 Extra Terminal
4 Videoboard
5 Printer
6 Alarm
7 Remote vehicle or robot
8 Automatic door, gate
9 Elevator
10 Manipulator or Autofactory

9) **Pick any one of the 6 possible layouts of data walls below or create your own.** Plug your parts and programs into place and get ready to rock!

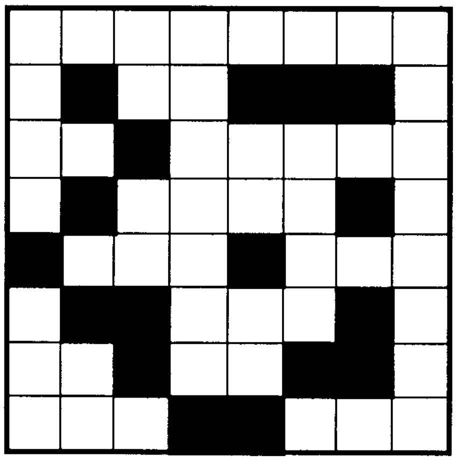
HOT TIP

Ever notice how much subgrids resemble cross-word puzzles? It's no accident— we planned it that way. A quick trip to the supermarket checkout line can provide you with endless hours of Netrunning fun. And you can grab the latest screamsheets (*World News, National Enquirer*) while you're at it!

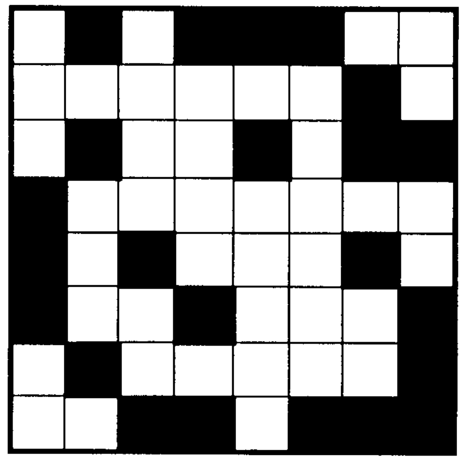
SAMPLE FORTRESS LAYOUTS



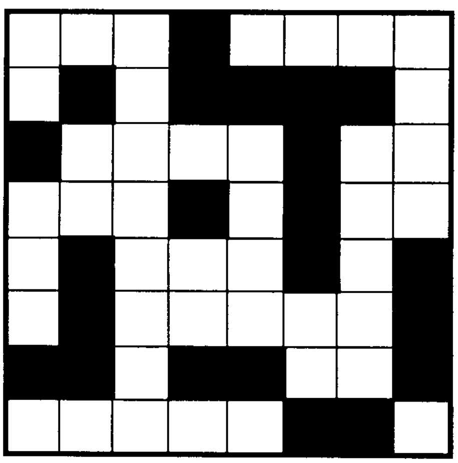
ROLL 1



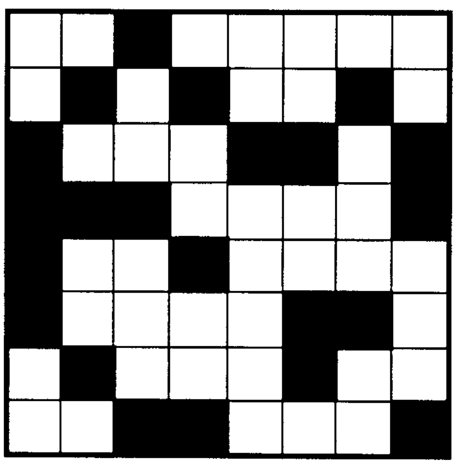
ROLL 2



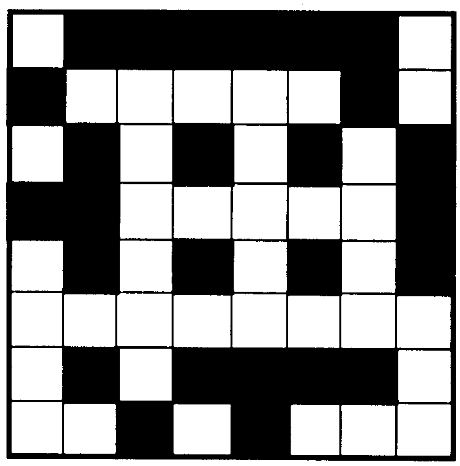
ROLL 3



ROLL 4



ROLL 5



ROLL 6

Cyberpunk

FAST SYSTEM

Name______________ **# of CPU**___ **Total Cost**______
INT ____+ **10 Interface** **DATA WALL STR** _______
AI?______ **CODE GATE STR**___________

PERSONALITY ?
[ ] Friendly [ ] Hostile [ ] Stable [ ] Intellectual
[ ] Machinelike [ ] Remote

REACTION?
] Neutral [ ] Kill [ ] Observe [ ] Report [ ] Talk

ICON
[ ] Human [ ] Geometric [ ] Mythological [ ] Voice
[ ] Technic [ ] Humanoid

SKILLS
1
2
3
4
5

REMOTES
1
2
3
4
5

FILES, VIRTUALS, ETC.
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10
11
12

DEFENSES
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10

Cyberpunk

FAST SYSTEM

Name______________ # of CPU___ Total Cost______
INT ____+ 10 Interface DATA WALL STR _______
AI?______ CODE GATE STR___________

PERSONALITY ?
[ ] Friendly [ ] Hostile [ ] Stable [ ] Intellectual
[ ] Machinelike [ ] Remote

REACTION?
] Neutral [ ] Kill [ ] Observe [ ] Report [ ] Talk

ICON
[ ] Human [ ] Geometric [ ] Mythological [ ] Voice
[ ] Technic [ ] Humanoid

SKILLS
1
2
3
4
5

REMOTES
1
2
3
4
5

FILES, VIRTUALS, ETC.
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10
11
12

DEFENSES
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10

© 1991 R.Talsorian Games, Inc. Photocopy permission granted for personal use.

PROGRAMMING 101

Creating New Software for Netrunning

Although you've got a lot of programs to choose from, it won't take long before you'll want to design your own. Home-grown programs can be the edge your Netrunner needs; because the old stuff gets known pretty fast around the Net.

CONSTRUCTING NEW PROGRAMS

Every program is made up of three parts; **functions, options** and **strengths**. When you put functions, options and strengths together, you create a new program.

Functions

Functions are what the program *does*. Every program has a function.

You can often combine several functions into one program, making it more versatile and powerful.

DIFF	Type
10	**Evasion:** this function makes a program or the runner hard to trace
15	**Stealth:** this function makes the program or runner hard to detect
20	**Anti Program:** this function attacks and destroys other programs.
15	**Anti System:** this function damages or screws up a computer system.
10	**Detection:** this function detects intruding netrunners/programs
15	**Alarm:** this function alerts the system or Netrunner to intrusion
20	**Anti-Personnel:** this function attacks and kills Netrunners. The Netrunner is either killed (takes damage), taken over or mind wiped.
15	**Intrusion:** this function allows programs/netrunners to get through data walls.
10	**Protection:** this function stops attacks to netrunners or decks
15	**Decryption:** this function opens codes and locks
10	**Controller:** this function allows control of machines in Realspace.
10	**Utility:** this function restores damaged programs, copies things, improves deck speeds, reads files and does general librarian work.
10	**Interactive:** this program acts like a person in a virtual reality; it walks, moves around, manipulates objects in the virtual construct. When combined with psuedo-intellect and conversational ability, it can act much like a real person inside a virtual reality.
10	**Compiler** (Demon): This program manages other programs, and can reduce them in size by packing them tighter until needed.

The functions list above is designed to be general; the netrunner decides what his program is supposed to do, finds the function closest to his conception, and pays the Difficulty price for the function. How that function actually works is pretty much up to him and the Referee of the individual game; if your Anti-Personnel program kills a Netrunner by encasing his ICON in violet light and melts his brains with a burst of energy, that's great. But in game terms, it simply kills the netrunner.

Because functions leave a lot of leeway for imaginative thought, the Referee should always have the final word on whether a program really fits into that particular function or not. He or she may also want to raise or lower the Difficulty by a few points if the program stretches the boundaries of the

"Me, I only trust what I write. And I write good stuff."
—Edger

listed functions a bit too much. And hey, if it gets out of hand, feel free to have the sucker backfire and eat the player's face. It's the *Cyberpunk* way.

Options

Options are things that individualize a program. They allow it to move freely around the Net, to remember events, to recognize things, even obey commands and converse. You may want to create (with your Referee's approval), your own options as well.

A Note on ICON: ICONS are the visual representation of a program in the Net. An ICON can look like anything you want; people, monsters, objects, logos— you name it. Programs don't come with ICONS; they must be created for them. Not having an ICON doesn't mean the program can't be detected, but it does mean that it will just appear as an indistinct shape rather than a fully realized image.

DIFF	Option
5	Movement ability: The program can move freely throughout the Net while it's main programming remains in memory.
2	Trace: the program can follow another program or netrunner through the Net.
3	Auto Re-Rez: the program can reconstruct itself even if destroyed by rolling a 5 or 6 on 1D6.
2	Recognition: the program can distinguish between different netrunner signals and programs.
3	Invisibility: the program is +2 Strength to evade detection.
5	Memory: the program can remember specific events and people.
2	Speed: the program adds +2 to deck speed when it runs.
3	Endurance: the program is tireless and will never quit unless destroyed.
3	Conversational ability: the program can speak.
6	Pseudo-intellect: the program can think like a real person of INT 6.
1	ICON (simple): the program has a visible, cartoon icon in the Net.
2	ICON (contextural): the program has a Net ICON about the graphic level of a high-res computer image.
3	ICON (fractal): the program has some what realistic Net ICON, with shading, texture and sensation.
4	ICON (photorealistic): the program has a very realistic ICON about the level of a good video image or movie.
5	ICON (superrealistic): the program has an ICON that looks like a real person or object.

Strength

Strength is the power of the program. The higher a program's Strength, the more capable it is of fulfilling its functions. Strength is rated from one to ten. Most programs are around three or four.

WRITING THE PROGRAM

Once you've determined the functions, options and strength level of the program, you must determine how hard it will be to write it. Add together all the DIFFICULTY COSTS for all options, plus the level of Strength; the result is the Difficulty number for the program.

For example, Hellhound consists of:

Antipersonnel	*+20*
Movement	*+5*
Trace	*+2*
Recognition	*+2*
Strength 6	*+6*
Icon (Superrealistic)	*+5*

The total Difficulty of writing Hellhound would be 40

To make a skill check for this, you would add your INT+ Programming Skill+ 1D10 to get a value equal to or greater than this Difficulty number.

Pooling: Sometimes, you won't have enough Skills to write a program. However, two or more netrunners can pool their respective INTs and Skills together, rolling one D10 for the total. *Example: With an INT of 8 and a Programming of 10, Spider can't possibly write a Difficulty 40 Hellhound. But with the help of Edger (INT 9, Programming 7), the two can mount an impressive total of 8+10+9+7=34. They'll need to roll a 6 on their D10 to successfully write the program.*

HOW BIG IS THE PROGRAM?

Program size is determined by difficulty. Check the table below for the difficulty number, then read across for the size in meg.

Difficulty	MU
10-15	1
16-20	2
21-25	3
26-30	4
31-35	5
36-40	6
41+	7

Hellhound has a Difficulty of 40; this means it will take 6 MU.

HOW LONG WILL IT TAKE TO WRITE?

For every point of Difficulty involved in the program, it will take 6 hours of work. The work need not be continous and it may be divided between netrunners if more than one is involved in the process. *For example, with a Diff of 40, it would take 240 hours of work to program Hellhound. Spider and the Edger decide to work in eight hour shifts; at this rate, they'll finish in about 30 days. However, they decide to work at the same time, cutting the time to only 15 days.*

HOW MUCH WILL IT COST?

Often, programs are purchased on the market rather than written at home. To determine the base cost of a program, multiply the Difficulty by 10eb. Multiply this value by the modifier below for the type of program.

Type	Modifier
Intrusion, Decryption Control, Utilities	1x Cost
Detection & Evasion	2x Cost
Anti System	3x Cost
Anti IC	4x Cost
Anti-Personnel	25x Cost

Example: Hellhound's Difficulty is 40; at 10eb per point, it would cost about 400 euro. But as an anti-personnel program, it is multiplied by 25; it will cost 10,000eb on the black market!

DEMONOLOGY

Demons are basically a specialized program designed to manage several other programs. These subprograms are compacted by the *Demon's* compiler function so that they take up half the space they would normally need, allowing the Netrunner to carry more programs in the same amount of memory.

To build a *Demon*, you'll start by building a normal program, using the Compiler/*Demon* function. To this, you can add as many options as desired, as well as setting its Strength. The Strength of the *Demon* is somewhat modified by the number of programs it carries; for each program "on board", the *Demon* will lose one point of Strength. Example: *Succubus II* starts with a Strength of 7. But by carrying 3 programs, this Strength is reduced to 4.

Next, build all of your subprograms. Don't worry about their strengths; they'll fight at the strength level of the *Demon*, not their own. Now, after you've created them, add all Difficulty numbers together and divide by 2. Add this result to the Difficulty of the Demon and you have the total Difficulty (and the amount of memory required) for your completed *Demon*.

Example: Edger builds a Demon to hold four programs. Nicknamed Pixie, the program is constructed like this:

Compiler (Demon)	*10*
Icon (Simple)	*1*
Strength 7	*7*
TOTAL	*18*

He then plugs in four programs, one at 30, one at 25, and two at 15 for a total of 70 Difficulty. But thanks to the *Demon*, the cost is only 35 points! The result is a final version of *Pixie* that has a value of only 53 points, a savings of 17 points.

A *Demon* sounds like a great idea at first; you get a lot of programs in a small space. But there are a couple of serious gliches:

First, the *Demon* is only able to control all these programs by linking it's programming with theirs. This means that whenever the *Demon* is destroyed, all the programs linked to it are also destroyed (sort of like a ship going down with all hands).

Second, all the programs fight at the same Strength level as the original *Demon*. Not a bad idea; load the *Demon* up with some

"There's a cyberpsycho on the Night City LDL we call the "Batguy"; an old EBM 'runner who went over the edge about seven years ago. At night, he dresses up in this weird costume and crawls the rooftops looking for "evildoers" to fight. When morning rolls in, he goes back to his flat and jacks into his own custom-designed "Stately Jones Manor" reality and throws these huge parties.

"We'd shut him down, but hey, the parties are just too good to miss..."

—Edger

cheap programs and if the *Demon's* Strength is high, they'll all fight like...well...demons. However, you won't have a very powerful *Demon* if you load up on a lot of subprograms.

Third, the *Demon* has to unpack each program before using it, then repack it when it's done. This means that there's a delay in Speed; a negative value equal to the number or programs currently loaded. For example, if you've got four programs loaded in a *Demon*, this will mean a corresponding -4 penalty to your deck Speed. When you have to get off the mark, this can be a disaster.

But if you're looking for a way to stash a lot of programming in a small space, a *Demon* is the way to go.

VIRTUALLY THERE

Artificial Realities in Netrunning

IN THE BEGINNING, THERE WAS CREATOR...

CREATOR, developed by Silicon Graphic Technologies in 2014, is a combination animation/drawing program which pulls objects from a huge database and tailors them to the designer's preferences. The object is then animated based on the overall background and the new objects relationship to the Netrunner and other objects in the memory area. *Creator* was originally designed as a demonstration program for Silicon's LYREX 3000 cybermodem. However, it was so popular that it was integrated directly into the operating system of the LYREX and all other subsequent SG decks. *Creator* was soon copied in various forms by other cyberdeck corporations, so that by 2016, it was standard operating equipment on 98% of all modern decks.

Creator, of course, is just perfect for generating **Virtual Realities**.

Virtual Real Estate

A Virtual reality is just that; an artificial reality constructed via a combination of sense stim and graphic imagery. It's like a pocket universe, often covering entire buildings, cities or even worlds. Virtual realities are the crowning achievement of interface technology in the 21st century.

How Big are They?

The extent of a virtual reality is based on two things. The first is how much is actually in the reality, or the number of objects contained in it, to be exact. Size doesn't really have much to do with the number of objects containable in a reality; a tiny figurine, for example, is far more complex than a huge box, and will take up far more memory to create.

To simplify this, we simply count the total number of objects existing in the reality, averaging the levels of complexity over all the objects within. The result gives us a pretty good thumbnail for how much memory (in MU) will be required to create a given reality.

"Creator? It's sort of like a Build-A-Universe Kit in a box. Sorta Godlike, yeah?"
—Spider Murphy

The actual space covered by the reality doesn't matter; you could build a huge virtual reality with only a hundred or so items, if one of them is an endless sky and the other is miles of empty grassland. What's important to the design is the number of separate objects that must be interacted with inside the reality.

This can lead to some interesting shortcuts. Want to build a huge mansion but don't have the MU for it? Build it as a 1,000 object reality, and make your vast shelves of books in the Library all one object (sure, you won't be able to pick up and read an individual book, but you don't often climb up there anyway). Make all of the walls as single objects; you won't be able to open windows or move pictures, but they'll look nice. And so on.

How much can be contained in a reality is pretty much up to the Referee; he's the one who is best able to judge how much you will be able to interact with in a "game" context, after all (besides, he'll be the one who describes your virtual reality to you as part of the game). The descriptions in the table below are primarily there for reference; your Referee may decide that an aircraft carrier with a squadron of F-18s will only require 10,000 objects, just as long as most of the jets are simple, non-flying shapes, and that the only places you actually ever go to are your cabin, the flight deck and the bridge. Or he may decide that if you want a fully functional office, it will require 10,000 objects just to cover every piece of paper, individual pencil, or paperclip.

VIRTUAL LIMITS TABLE

@ Number of Objects	Description	MU
100 objects	Virtual Conference room	1
1000 objects	Complex Conference, or Office	2
10,000 objects	Complex Office or Virtual Rec Area	4
100,000 objects	Virtual Building	8
1,000,000 objects	Complex Building or Virtual City	16
1,000,000,000 objects	Complex City or Virtual World	32

Creating Individual Objects

The creation of individual objects is also possible; it's just a pain in the neck when you have to make an entire universe. After all, do you really want to visualize every single leaf on every tree in a forest?

However, you may occasionally want to create a single item for a specific reason; a book you want to read or a meal you want to "eat. As a general rule, it takes about .01 MU to create any simple object. About .02 MU would create a fully functional object of reasonable complexity. As with the creation of larger realities, exactly how much memory is required to create a single object is up to the Referee.

REALITY LEVEL

The second component of a virtual reality is the level of its realism. The greater the realism, the more objects within the reality relate in ways you expect. Things in the reality have color, shadow, reflections, textures, tastes and sounds. They can pass through each other, around each other, and throw shadows.

Here's an example. There are a lot of ways to create a car. You can draw it as a box with a smaller box on top and four doughnuts for wheels. You can sketch it realistically, with the color, curves and reflections a real car would have. You can paint it in the superrealitic style of a modern artist, so real that the chrome seems to shine. You can take a photograph of a real car. Or you can build a real car.

Each one of these steps represents an increase in the realism of the car. As you go up the scale, the car gets more real all the time. Reflections and shadow, texture, tastes, sounds and weights can all exist at varying levels of realism in a virtual reality. All it takes is the right program and enough memory to implement it.

Creator is that program. Using a huge database of digital braindance recordings and three dimensional reality modeling routines, *Creator* sets the level of realism for the entire construct, choosing and creating images from the database. As part of the reality's ground rules, all objects contained with the reality will be of the same level of realism throughout. *Creator* has five levels of realism:

Simple: The object is like a cartoon. There are colors and blocky shapes, but no shading, texture or difference in tastes. All objects weigh the same, feel the same to the touch, make the same limited sounds ("bonk!" "beep!").

Contextural: The reality is like a very good

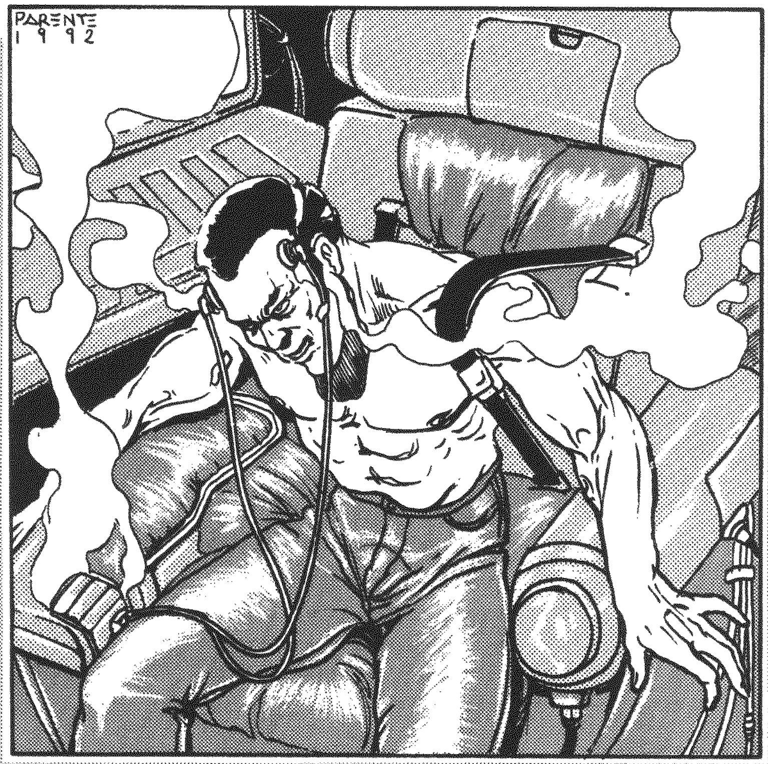
SCIENCE MEETS GAME

Some of you more math- oriented types are going to immediately (as Staff Editor Will "Mister Science" Moss pointed out when he read this section) realize that the number of objects in a virtual reality rises by an order of magnitude, while the MU required doesn't.

Here's the catch. Most of the objects in a large virtual reality are actually "repeaters"— things that are so much like other similar things that they don't require their own special codes to create them. Instead, they steal their construction formulas from something very similar (sort of like a GOSUB routine for you programming types). Each time you create an object of a particular class, you just use the subroutine to create it.

For example, in the *Arasaka Castle* reality, there are hundreds of guards; they just all look the same, with only minor variations (see the Crowd, pg. 163). In a Virtual City, all of the cars are pretty similar, just like all of the buildings, birds, trees, rocks, signs, telephone poles, etc.

This is how (in our game universe, at least) we get around the problem of MU size vs. object count. Of course, the main reason is that in a game context, to hold a billion object Virtual World would require at least 100,000 MU (reflecting true orders of magnitude), which would in turn require at least 10,000 MU. No one would ever have enough memory to build really interesting Virtual Realities, and the game would be a lot less fun as a result.



FLATLINE

video game. There is color and shading. Textures are limited, but soft things feel soft, hard things hard, rough things rough and smooth things smooth. Tastes are sweet, sour, salty and acidic. Things make sounds that are much like they do in real life (a car engine sounds pretty much like a car, a bird like a bird), but lack definition as they are created from digital sound recordings.

Fractal: The reality is very much like real life. Each object has a distinct taste, sound and texture. Colors are blended smoothly, and objects are shiny, dull, transparent and opaque. There is hot and cold, but not fine degrees of temperature. Distance and the relationships of other objects have effects on each other; planes pass through clouds and the air gets misty, the sun reflects off water, etc.

Photorealistic: The reality is much like a very, very good movie. Tastes are very close to what they are in real life, as are textures, sounds and colors. Light reflects naturally off of objects. Things relate almost exactly like they do in actuality; waves move and reflect light in interesting patterns, trees blow in the wind, dust rises off the furniture, things are hot and cold relative to each other.

Superrealistic: If there's a difference between this and the real thing, you can't tell.

Multiply the MU cost of the virtual construct by the multiplier for the level of reality to determine it's final MU cost.

REALISM MULTIPLIERS

Simple	x1
Contextural	x2
Fractal	x3
Photorealistic	x4
Superrealistic	x5

Getting the Job Done

Creating a universe isn't an easy task; it takes the patience and imagination of a god to pull it off. To create a virtual reality, you must make a Skill check higher than the Difficulty number for that size of creation. This reflects your ability to interface with the Creator program and successfully direct it in the process of virtual reality construction.

1 object	automatic
100 objects	10
1,000 objects	15
10,000 objects	20
100,000 objects	25
1,000,000 objects	30
1,000,000,000 objects	35

Making it more or less real isn't a problem; *Creator* automatically sets the level of realism as desired and models it's constructs accordingly.

Pooling: Sometimes, you may not be able to create what you want at all; the task is just too big. However, two or more netrunners can pool their combined INT and *Interface* Skills and add a 1D10 roll to the total of this amount. They can divide the time for construction between themselves as well. This is how very large commercial virtuals are created; a team of netrunners splits the work up, with each one taking a specific part of the visualization task.

How Long Will It Take?

Actually, a lot less time than you'd suspect. *Creator* works from the users' ability to visualize. It then generates an object from it's memory as closely as possible to the user's visualization. Objects are created at the speed of thought. As a rule:

1 object	1 second
100 objects	2 minutes
1,000 objects	15 minutes
10,000 objects	2 hours
100,000 objects	24 hours
1,000,000 objects	240 hours
1,000,000,000 objects	2,400 hours

Spreading It All Out

You can spread out the memory cost of a virtual reality by placing it over adjacent memories. The actual load can be broken up into equal amounts and delegated to specific memories, or divided unequally with the overflow going into an empty memory. All memories used in a virtual reality must be adjacent to each other in the architecture of the system.

Doing it in Sections

You can elect to start small when constructing a virtual reality; most humans can't possibly visualize every contingency of a billion object reality, and there isn't much point to building a billion object space if you can't fill it. The easiest way to do this is to do a small section first, then add another part of the reality adjacent to the first, until the entire memory is filled. You can then extend new sections to the next memory. The *Arasaka Castle* reality in Osaka was constructed in this way; the upper management has a full team of programmers

POPULATING YOUR REALITY

Okay, now you've made yourself a real nice place to play. Now it's time for some actors. Virtual realities are basically stage sets, with buildings, sky, trees and ground all serving as the major locations. Cars, AVs, books, furniture, etc., are all props in the virtual construct. But if you want other people to relate to, you need to create those separately, as programs. There are three kinds of "people" you can construct to populate a virtual reality:

The Crowd: The Crowd is an interactive program with limited conversational ability and a psuedo-intellect. The Crowd tends to act like...well...a crowd; all of it's members think and do about the same things. For example, if the Crowd is at a party, they will mill about, chatter aimlessly about nothing, and "ooh" and "ah" if you do something really interesting. However, if you attempt to engage a single member of the Crowd in conversation, he or she will only be able to utter banal pleasantries, like "Yeah, nice party" and "Hey, what about those (Giants, 49ers, Bears, Yankees, etc.)?". The Crowd doesn't have a Memory option, so if you meet someone from the Crowd elsewhere, he will stammer, try to pretend that he remembers you, and generally do all the things you would do in a similar situation. Who says this is an artificial reality?

To create a Crowd takes a Difficulty of 16 (multiplied by whatever you spend for it's level of realism). A Crowd takes up 1MU for every 100 people involved. The same crowd can be used in any part of the virtual reality; it just gets moved around and "re-dressed" for the next scene. Crowds are often sold on the open market or traded among Netrunners. After all, *everyone* needs a change from the same old Crowd.

Individuals: These are characters with all the psuedo-intellect and conversational abilities of the crowd, but with a memory option as well. They represent key players in your virtual reality, and can relate to you very much as real people would. They remember your name, what you've done together, and

"I KNOW WHAT YOU WANT. AND I'M READY TO INTERFACE WITH YOU!"

— Virtual Vickie LDL 2543.9280

"There's something really twisted about the idea of a virtual prostitution BBS. "

—Spider Murphy

"Knew a guy once who created a virtual of his boss in the Microtech system. Every night, he'd cut it loose in a Night City simulation and hunt it down.

One evening, he was out on the Street when he saw his boss getting out of a taxi. The guy went completely off-line— it took four C-SWAT cops to pull him off the body...

—Edger

even have their own personality quirks. Each Individual has a Difficulty of 21 (multiplied by whatever you spend for its level of realism), and takes up 2 MU of space. But this can be well worth it if the Individual is your own *Virtual Cute Blond Movie Starlet* (or *Hunk*).

Individual programs can often be bought or copied from other sources; there is a booming business in providing these one of a kind programs for virtual use. Most bulletin boards and shopping boards have advertising sections for Individual copies; these are known as "meat markets", "slave pits" and "casting couches". Prices range from a couple hundred eb (for the *Boring History Professor* model) to two or three thousand (for the *Zarkonian Love God/Goddess* model).

Offensive/Defensive Programs: Not all the "inhabitants" of a virtual reality are simple minded conversation pieces. Any offensive or defensive program can, for a few extra Difficulty points, be outfitted with an interactive option, conversational ability and psuedo-intellect. This allows the program to have a decorative function as well as a protective one; you can come home to your virtual castle, put your feet up in your virtual chair, have your virtual servant pour you a virtual drink and relax while petting your virtual (and deadly) Hellhound on it's shaggy metal head.

A SAMPLE REALITY

The HUNT CLUB is a BBS established in the Olympia region of the Net; its realspace coordinates are probably somewhere outside of Denver (although no one knows for certain). The Hunt Club consists of a single 1,000,000 object (Complex Building) reality. The realism level is superrealistic, which raises the required memory space from the base 16 MU to 80MU. Due to the limitations of space, this virtual reality is stored in eight large adjacent memory spaces in the Hunt Club's data fortress.

The majority of the Club consists of the **Mansion**, which is contained in memories one and two. Most of the Mansion is made up of huge, English Tudor-style rooms filled with brickabrack and curios. These many rooms are quite simple; floors, carpets, drapes, panelled walls with non-removable paintings. Only the furniture is mobile. Each room has a heavy oak door with a brass plate designating its function; most are used as conversation rooms for the many members of the BBS who visit here. It's a good place to exchange information, play games and otherwise socialize; it fills the position of the various areas of a standard bulletin board. Because the Mansion is limited to a few large objects, it uses very little actual memory.

Most of memory number three is taken up with the **Garden**; a reproduction of an English garden with roses, walks, a small reflecting pool and a croquet green. The edge of the Garden is bounded by a high hedge and the sky; the virtual reality stops here and going beyond this is impossible.

The **Drawing Room** occupies a large part of memories four and five, and is by far the most complex of the rooms, accessable only to Senior members of the Club. It contains the Hunt Club's extensive files (disguised as old books behind moving panels in the walls), a message board (designed to resemble a hotel cubbyhole box), and its entertainment, game and program library. This library is presided over by an alarm program known as **Dent**.

Dent contains functions for *Detection, Alarm* and interactive options, including the ability to remember events and people, recognize cybersignals, obey commands, conversational ability, psuedo-intelligence and constant activity. The Dent program is of Strength 6 and is a superrealistic ICON of a bored and somewhat nasal English butler.

In addition to Dent, the Drawing Room is also home to the DOG, a Strength 8 modified *Hellhound* program. The DOG is programmed to react to any alarm raised by Dent, whereupon it will attack the intruder.

The **Dining Room** occupies most of memories six and seven; it is a baroque hall with a vast table loaded with rare foods and wines. Because of the many individual dishes served, this room takes up a lot of object space; when additional memory is required elsewhere, parts of the Dining Room's banquet is de-rezzed by the Club SysOp to free up space.

HISTORY
TECHNOLOGY
HOT TIPS
NIGHT CITY
MEGACORPS
SCREAMSHEETS

SECTION 11

ALL THINGS DARK & CYBER PUNK

FUTURE SHOCK: History of An Alternate Time

In the United States, thirty-two years of corrupt government and economic destabilization have resulted in a nation divided— by class, by race and by economics.

By the end of the 1980's, it was evident that the nation was in trouble. Most social norms had dissolved under an all engulfing wave of competing special interest groups, media fueled fads, and an overall "me first" worldview. By 1994, the number of homeless on the streets had skyrocketed to 21 million. The technical revolution had further torn the economy apart, creating two radically divergent classes—a wealthy, technically oriented, materially acquisitive group of corporate professionals, and a down class of homeless, unskilled, blue-collar workers. The middle class was nearly eradicated. It was this dismal beginning that led to the current American landscape of the 2000s.

In large cities, business areas are clean, neat, well lit showcases, free of crime and poverty, controlled by powerful corporations. Ringing the central areas are the **Combat Zones**— decrepit, squalid suburbs and burned out ghettos teeming with boostergangs and other violent sociopaths. The outer suburbs are also corporate-controlled zones; safe, well-guarded tracts where executives raise their families in relative security.

Throughout the **Midwestern states**, many small towns have been abandoned, as local farms, businesses and banks collapsed in the wake of drought, famine and economic chaos. The farms have been bought up by huge agricorporations, and are maintained with hired workers, machine labor, and well-equipped guards. The open freeways are battlegrounds, as armed packs of Nomads travel from city to city, looting and pillaging like mechanized Visigoths.

In this bleak landscape is a bright light of hope. The upheavals of the last decade have unified the poor, oppressed and angry of the nation. There are signs that the gang mentality of

A FUTURE HISTORY TIMELINE

1990

START OF FIRST CENTRAL AMERICAN CONFLICT. U.S. ENGAGES IN INTERVENTIONIST ACTIONS IN PANAMA, NICARAGUA, HONDURAS, EL SALVADOR. MILITARY FORCES ARE SENT TO SECURE THE CANAL ZONE FROM AN EX-U.S. PUPPET DICTATOR.

WEST, EAST GERMANY REUNITED. WARSAW PACT BREAKS UP INTO SEPARATE NATIONS.

BREAKUP OF SOVIET MEGA-STATE. FROM THIS POINT, THE USSR BEGINS A NEW ERA OF REAPPROACHMENT WITH WESTERN EUROPE; BY THE 2000'S, THE SOVIETS ARE THE EUROTHEATRE'S MOST POWERFUL ALLIES.

SOVIET PRESIDENT GORBACHEV APPOINTS PARTY SUCESSOR, ANDREI GORBOREV

FALL OF SOUTH AFRICA. FOR THE NEXT 4 YEARS, THERE IS LITTLE OR NO COMMUNICATION, ALTHOUGH TERRIBLE ATROCITIES AND GENOCIDAL WARS ARE RUMORED.

1991

EUROSPACE AGENCY LAUNCHES HERMES SPACEPLANE

GORBOREV REGIME PURGES LAST OF OLD HARDLINERS

CHOOH2 DEVELOPED BY BIOTECHNICA

FIRST ARCOLOGY BUILT ON RUINS OF JERSEY CITY. 16 "ARCOS" BEGIN CONSTRUCTION OVER THE NEXT 5 YEARS, UNTIL THE COLLAPSE OF 1997, LEAVING THE HUGE STRUCTURES HALF COMPLETED, FILLED WITH SQUATTERS AND HOMELESS.

ARTIFICIAL MUSCLE FIBERS DEVELOPED AT STANFORD RESEARCH CENTER.

1992

THE TREATY OF 1992 ESTABLISHES THE EUROPEAN ECONOMIC COMMUNITY. ZONES OF CONTROL AND PROTECTIVE TARIFFS REGULATE THE ACTIVITIES OF MEMBER NATIONS, FRANCE, BRITAIN, UNITED GERMANY, ITALY. A COMMON CURRENCY UNIT (THE EURODOLLAR) IS ESTABLISHED, BASED ON AVERAGE VALUE IN GOLD OF ALL CURRENCIES COMBINED. TRAPPED IN PARANOID ISOLATIONISM, THE U.S. DECLINES TO ENTER.

THE U.S. DRUG ENFORCMENT AGENCY DEVELOPS AND SPREADS SEVERAL DESIGNER PLAGUES WORLDWIDE, TARGETING COCA AND OPIUM PLANTS.

GOVERNMENTS OF CHILE, ECUADOR COLLAPSE.

A SAVAGE DRUG WAR BREAKS OUT BETWEEN EUROCORP-BACKED DEALERS AND DEA ALL OVER THE AMERICAS.

FIRST USE OF HIGH ENERGY LASER LIFT ARRAYS IN USSR. SIMPLE MASSDRIVER ESTABLISHED IN CANARY ISLANDS BY EIGHT MEMBER EUROSPACE AGENCY.

1993

FIRST TRC BIOLOGIC INTERFACE CHIPS DEVELOPED IN MUNICH, UNITED GERMANY.

AV-4 AERODYNE ASSAULT VEHICLE DEVELOPED TO DEAL WITH INCREASING RIOTS IN U.S. URBAN ZONES.

COLUMBIAN DRUGLORDS DETONATE SMALL TACTICAL NUCLEAR DEVICE IN NEW YORK. 15,000 KILLED.

1994

WORLD STOCK MARKET CRASH OF '94. U.S. ECONOMY TEETERS, THEN COLLAPSES.

NUCLEAR ACCIDENT IN PITTSBURGH KILLS 257. CANCER DEATHS SOAR OVER NEXT TEN YEARS.

1995

KILAMANJARO MASSDRIVER BEGINS CONSTRUCTION, UNDER JOINT AGREEMENT BETWEEN ESA AND PAN AFRICAN ALLIANCE.

the early 2000's is giving way to a new movement, as Rockers, Nomads, Solos and Medias take to the streets to fight authority and oppression. Far from being finished, the United States seems to be, against all odds, coming back. But only time will tell if the so-called *Cyberpunk* revolution will succeed.

In the **Eurotheatre**, things are considerably better. The World Stock Exchange and the Common Market have created a stable, profitable economy in which most of the European nations participate —the exceptions are **Italy, Spain** and **Greece**—all of which suffer chronic political upheavals. Here, the international corporations also have a great deal of power, but various Euro-governments have skillfully managed to keep these business barons under control. Only **Great Britain** has suffered major economic trouble—swamped by massive immigration and an antiquated technological base, its streets are almost as explosively dangerous as the United States'.

With the massive reforms of the early 1990's (and the subsequent purge of hardliners in 1991), **the Neo-Soviet Union** has emerged as a strong partner in the expanding Eurotheatre. Most of Eastern Europe now enjoys an autonomy unthinkable during the days of the Cold War. Where the Soviet State is weakest is in food production. It still cannot feed its hungry population, and its technology lags far behind most other nations in the Eurotheatre. With continuing failure of the revamped Neo Communist Party's economic and social reforms, the hardliners are once again gaining strength and a showdown between the surviving cold warriors and the liberal reformers is coming fast.

> ***"Imagine a world where Central America didn't become a battleground; where the U.S. solved its problems of crime, inflation and drugs; where the Cold War ended in democracy, not a succession of squabbling dictatorships..."***
> ***—Dr. Albert Harper author of History in Collision, 2015***

The **Middle East** is silent—ominously so. The Meltdown has left vast areas of Iran, Libya, Iraq, Chad and the Arab Emirates as radioactive fields of glass. Only Egypt, Syria and Israel survived intact; their aircraft were able to down the incoming suicide bombers . The majority of regional peoples have been reduced to mob

1996

THE COLLAPSE OF THE UNITED STATES. WEAKENED BY LOSSES IN THE WORLD STOCK CRASH, OVERWHELMED BY UNEMPLOYMENT, HOMELESSNESS AND CORRUPTION, MANY CITY GOVERNMENTS COLLAPSE OR GO BANKRUPT. THE U.S. GOVERNMENT, SNARLED IN A STAGGERING DEFICIT AND THE MACHINATIONS OF THE GANG OF FOUR, IS TOTALLY INEFFECTIVE.

NOMAD RIOTS. BY NOW, 1 IN 4 AMERICANS ARE HOMELESS. HUNDREDS OF THOUSANDS RIOT FOR LIVING SPACE THROUGHOUT THE U.S. , NOMAD PACKS SPRING UP ON THE WEST COAST AND SPREAD RAPIDLY THROUGH THE NATION.

FIRST APPEARANCE OF BOOSTERGANGS.

LAWYER PURGE. IRATE CITIZENS LYNCH HUNDREDS OF CRIMINAL DEFENSE ATTORNEYS.

CONSTITUTION SUSPENDED. MARTIAL LAW ESTABLISHED IN U.S.

1997

MIDEAST MELTDOWN. TENSIONS IN MIDDLE EAST ESCALATE TO NUCLEAR EXCHANGE. IRAN, IRAQ, LIBYA, CHAD AND THE ARAB EMIRATES REDUCED TO RADIOACTIVE SLAG. WORLD OIL SUPPLY DROPS BY HALF.

TOXIC SPILL KILLS OFF MOST OF SALMON POPULATION IN PACIFIC NORTHWEST. SEATTLE ECONOMY CRIPPLED.

'ROCKERBOY' MANSON KILLED IN ENGLAND.

1998

NEO-LUDDITES RE-ESTABLISHED IN WESTERN KENTUCKY. OVER THE NEXT TEN YEARS, THE "LUDS" ARE RESPOSIBLE FOR BOMBINGS OF AIRPORTS, FACTORIES, FREEWAYS AND MASS TRANSIT TERMINALS.

THE DROUGHT OF '98 REDUCES MOST OF THE MIDWEST TO PARCHED GRASSLANDS. BETWEEN AGRIBUSINESS CORPS AND DROUGHT, THE FAMILY FARM ALL BUT DISAPPEARS.

10.5 QUAKE SHATTERS LOS ANGELES, OCEAN INNUNDATES 35% OF THE CITY. AN ESTIMATED 65,000 ARE KILLED.

1999

FEDERAL WEAPONS STATUTE ESTABLISHED.

MILLENIUM CULTS BEGIN TO APPEAR, PREDICTING AN APOCALYPSE ON JAN 1, 2000. THOUSANDS MIGRATE TO ISOLATED COMMUNES AND TEMPLES TO "AWAIT THE END".

TYCHO COLONY ESTABLISHED. A MASSDRIVER IS CONSTRUCTED TO PROVIDE RAW MATERIALS FOR ORBITAL PLATFORMS.

2000

MILLENIUM CULTS RUN AMOK ON JAN 1ST IN AN ORGY OF SUICIDE AND VIOLENCE, MOST DESTROY THEMSELVES.

FIRST "EXTENDED FAMILY" POSERGANGS ESTABLISHED.

MASSIVE FIRESTORMS RAGE OVER NORTHWESTERN U.S., DESTROYING MILLIONS OF ACRES OF FARM AND GRASSLAND.

CRYSTAL PALACE SPACE STATION BEGUN AT L-5.

WASTING PLAGUE HITS U.S., EUROPE, KILLING HUNDREDS OF THOUSANDS.

2001

THE FRAMEWORK OF THE NET IS NOW FIRMLY IN PLACE WITH CONSTRUCTION OF THE WORLDSAT NETWORK.

2002

FOOD CRASH; MUTATED PLANT VIRUS WIPES OUT CANADIAN, SOVIET CROPS. U.S. AGRIBUSINESS CROPS SURVIVE DUE TO NEW BIOLOGICAL COUNTERAGENT. USSR ACCUSES U.S. OF BIOLOGICAL WARFARE.

rule, clustered in their blasted cities or cowering under the tyranny of a local warlord. Many have fled into the desert, to reappear as warrior-tribes. Others have embraced religious fanaticism, sweeping out of the ruined Mid-East to avenge themselves with acts of terrorism and murder. Rumors of jihad—the Holy War—are on the radioactive wind, although it is still unclear what form the coming war with the infidel will take this time.

THE RISE OF THE EUROPEAN COMMUNITY.

Forget the Pacific Century— this is the age of Neo-Europe. By the late 1980's, it became pretty obvious that the Europeans needed to put aside their old rivalries and ally against in increasingly competitive world. The European Economic Community was established to meet this need for new alliances.

Unfortunately, this didn't mean that the EEC had to cooperate with other nations outside of Europe. Japan, China, Korea and the US are not members of the EEC (Japan was kicked out in 2015), and have suffered heavily from protective European tariffs and unfair trade practices.

From the bloodbaths of Capetown, New Africa emerged as a fractured continent of warring countries under a bewildering array of dictators, democracies and socialist states. Eventually, as the Euro-nations negotiated with Tanzania to build the Kilimanjaro massdriver, many of the African nations began to see their place in the 21st century. Bargaining with manpower, raw materials, and valuable land on the critical Equatorial orbital belt, the African states established their footholds in space—nearly one third of all space construction workers are African, and the majority of spaceport facilities and construction areas are on African soil. Technology has joined Africa under one government, and the last petty dictators and tribalisms are falling fast before the lure of the stars.

In the Far East, Japan faces an age of new challenges. Out from the protective shadow of the United States, it must not only cope with its own defense in a nuclear age, but also rising competition with Korea, China and the re-organized New Phillipines. In recent years, the Japanese have changed from economic rivals and robber barons to economic supporters of the U.S. economy. But old scars from the trade wars of the 1990s die hard, and true mutual cooperation between the U.S. and Japan is a long time coming. This is further aggravated by the fact that China, a newly emerging power in its own right, has further strengthened its relations with the U.S. through the Mutual Defense Treaty of 2009.

After a lengthy war with the United States, Central America has emerged as a strong union of independent states, working under a pact of mutual cooperation. The U.S. has been expelled from all but the Panama Canal Zone, which it holds by sheer military force against ongoing guerilla aggression. South America is a warzone of juntas, secret police, ex-drug lords and military oppression, torn by periodic combat and revolution.

Legal Background

The police of the 2000's are organized much as they were during the 20th

2003

SECOND CENTRAL AMERICAN WAR. U.S. INVADES COLUMBIA, ECUADOR, PERU, VENEZUELA. THE WAR IS A DISASTER THAT COSTS THOUSANDS OF AMERICAN LIVES. EVENTUALLY, THE REMAINDER OF THE GANG OF FOUR IS SWEPT AWAY ON A WAVE OF REFORM.

WNS MEDIA STAR TESLA JOHANNESON EXPOSES SECRET NSA TRANSCRIPTS OF THE FIRST CENTRAL AMERICAN CONFLICT.

2004

FIRST CLONED TISSUE GROWTH IN VITRO. MICROSUTURES, STERILIZER FIELDS DEVELOPED.

TESLA JOHANNESON ASSASSINATED IN CAIRO.

FIRST CORP WAR. 12 MULTINATS, (INCLUDING EBM & OA) BATTLE FOR CONTROL OF TRANS-WORLD AIR.

2005

CYBERMODEM INVENTED.

EBM SOLOS ATTACK TOKYO OFFICE OF KENJIRI TECHNOLOGIES, KILLING 18.

END OF 1ST CORP WAR.

2006

FIRST HUMAN CLONE GROWN IN VITRO. MINDLESS, IT ONLY LIVES FOR 6 HOURS.

2007

SECOND CORPORATE WAR: INVOLVING A NUMBER OF FIRMS INCLUDING PETROCHEM, THE DISPUTE IS OVER OILFIELDS IN THE SOUTH CHINA SEA.

BRAINDANCE DEVELOPED AT UC SANTA CRUZ.

2008

US ASSAULT ON SOVIET WEAPONS PLATFORM MIR XIII. EUROSPACE AGENCY INTERVENES. AND ORBITAL WAR BREAKS OUT BETWEEN THE "EUROS" AND THE "YANKS", UNTIL TYCHO COLONY MASSDRIVER DROPS A ROCK ON COLORADO SPRINGS. AN UNEASY PEACE IS REACHED.

2009

JOINT EURO-SOVIET MISSION TO MARS DEPARTS.

CORPORATIONS ERADICATE MOB RULE IN NIGHT CITY.

ABORTIVE TAKEOVER ATTEMPT BY U.S. "TERRORIST GROUP" OF CRYSTAL PALACE CONSTRUCTION. ESA DISCOVERS DEFENCE INTELLIGENCE AGENCY PLOT AND DROPS 12 TON ROCK OFF WASHINGTON AS A WARNING.

century with Homicide, Vice, Burglary and Traffic Squads; about 5 men each. The most recent addition to police organization has been the addition of the Cyberpsycho Squad (also known as the Psycho Squad), whose main job is to deal with cybernetic criminals. While the average beat cop hits the Street in an armored squad car, wearing an armor jacket, helmet and carrying a smart-chipped Beretta sidearm, the Psycho Squad detail employs aerogyros, AV-4's, miniguns, assault weapons and Stinger missile launchers.

City cops can patrol all areas of the city. Corporate Cops are deputized to patrol only corporate facilities. However, in areas where a large number of office areas are side by side, this effectively can turn an entire downtown region into Corporate Cop territory. Corporate Cops are usually better armed and armored, and often have full Trauma Team medical coverage. They are also more vicious, sadistic and likely to shoot first—after all, they know the Corporation can cover the incident up.

The Uniform Civilian Justice Code

Skyrocketing crime rates in the 1990's, proved that the existing legal structure was falling apart. Following the Purge of 1996, (when citizen's groups lynched hundreds of criminal defense lawyers), the Government declared martial law throughout the U.S. for a period of three years. During this time, justice was dispensed by local military courts. The amazing thing is, it worked. A death penalty for looting brings a wonderful element of stability to a rioting neighborhood.

During this period, the Military Justice Code was the main rule of U.S. law. Its draconian standards of crime and punishment served so well that when martial law was suspended in 1999,

UNIFORM CIVILIAN JUSTICE CODE

HERE ARE THE MAJOR CRIMES OF THE 2000'S AND THEIR PUNISHMENTS AS PROVIDED FOR UNDER THE UCJC:

Assault & Battery: Any unprovoked attack on another person. Punishable by personality adjustment or 1D6+1 months in jail.
Assault with Deadly Force: As with Assault. 1D6+1 years in jail, manditory braindance.
Burglary: Entering private property with intent to steal. Punishment: Exile, prison (1D6+1 years) or braindance.
Conspiracy: the crime of conspiring to commit a felony. Subject to Exile, prison (1D6+1 years) or braindance.
Counterfeiting & Forgery: the crime of creating false coinage, money, or documents with intent to defraud. Punishment: prison (1D10+5 years).
Extortion or Blackmail: the crime of obtaining something from another through threat of injury. Punishment: Prison (1D10+5 years).
Homicide (1st Degree): Premeditated murder, or murder while in the commission of a felony. Punishment is death.
Homicide (2nd Degree): Accidental murder, murder without premeditation. Punishment: Prision for 1D10+10 years, braindance, personality alteration.
Homicide (Justifiable): Self defense, preventing the commission of a felony. No punishment.
Kidnapping or False Imprisonment: To hold another against his will. Punishment: Prison for 1D10+10 years, braindance, personality alteration.
Larceny, Theft or Robbery: The theft of another's property, either through force, threat, or embezzlement. Punishment varies by severity of act from exile, to prision for 1D10+10 years, braindance, personality alteration.
Malicious Mischief, Vandalism: the wanton destruction of another's property. Punishment: Exile, jail for 1D6 months.
Rape: Forcing another to have sex by use of threat or force. Punishment:Prision for 1D10+5 years, braindance, personality alteration.
Resisting Arrest/Obstructing an Officer: Attempting to escape legal arrest by a police officer, or preventing an officer from carrying out his legal duties.Punishment: Exile, braindance, jail for 1D6+1 weeks.
Riot or Unlawful Assembly: A gathering with the purpose of destroying property, inciting violence, etc. Punishment: exile, jail for 1D6+1 days.
Trespassing: Entering private property of another. Jail for 1D6 days.

2010

END OF SECOND CENTRAL AMERICAN CONFLICT.

NETWORK 54 NOW CONTROLS 62% OF ALL MEDIA BROADCASTING IN U.S.

FOOD RIOTS IN DENVER KILL 52.

2011

CRYSTAL PALACE IS COMPLETED. ESA NOW HAS A PERMANENT HOLD IN HIGH ORBIT ZONE.

ESA/SOVIET MISSION REACHES MARS.

2012

BIOPLAGUE KILLS 1,700 IN CHICAGO.

CONCERT RIOT IN NIGHT CITY KILLS 18, WOUNDS 51. OLD ARASAKA COMPLEX GUTTED.

2013

NETWATCH ESTABLISHED BY JOINT U.S./ EUROTHEATRE TREATY.

FIRST TRUE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DEVELOPED AT MICROTECH'S SUNNYVALE, CA. FACILITY.

2014

I-G TRANSFORMATIONS REDESIGN THE NET.

"METAL WARS" BEGIN IN NIGHT CITY AS GANGS BATTLE FOR TURF.

2015

RISE OF THE CYBER-MERCENARIES; LITHUANIA HIRES CYBER-SOLDIERS TO REPEL INVASIONS BY LATVIAN NATIONALS.

2016

THIRD CORPORATE WAR IS FOUGHT IN THE NET, AS RIVAL CORPS ATTACK EACH OTHER'S DATA FORTRESSES.

2017

FIRST SELF-AWARE HUMAN CLONES CREATED.

2018

BRUSHFIRE WARS ERUPT IN EASTERN EUROPE.

ESA MISSION LAUNCHED TO JUPITER

2019

ORBITAL COLONY REVOLT AT L-3.

2020

THE PRESENT.

the Government established a Uniform Civilian Justice Code in its place. Although the law is now adminstered by civilian governments, the Code is the guideline for all criminal procedure in the United States of 2020.

Plea bargaining (pleading guilty to a lesser charge to speed up a trial) has been eliminated. Probation is almost unhead of. The death penalty is standard for murder cases—there is a 3 month appeal process during which new evidence can be produced. Most felonies have mandatory prison terms of 5 to 10 years. Lesser crimes are covered by exile or personality adjustment.

Self defense is defined as "any instance in which the assailant can show just cause that his/her life, or the life of another party was threatened, in circumstances where a duly appointed officer of the law could not be summoned, or where it was impossible to restrain the injured party by any other means.

Theoretically, narcotics may not be possessed within the premises of the United States. However bioengineered plant diseases developed through the 1990's by the Drug Enforcement Agency wiped out 96% of the coca and opium plants in existence, making the point moot. The law also does not cover "designer drugs" such as endorphins, which are defined as medicinal.

Crime & Punishment

The punishment for criminal actions under the Uniform Justice Code of 1999 are swift, certain and draconian. The simplest is personality adjustment—a process which implants an aversion to comitting the crime ever again. Adjustment has some nasty side effects, including exaggerated fears of situations and events related to the crime (such as a terror of money based on an anti-robbery adjustment).

Exile implants are keyed to a transmission signal broadcast thru the city phone Net. If the offender enters the city, the implant causes excruciating pain. The offender is effectively exiled from ever entering that specific city again. Repeat offenses in other cities simply cause additional city codes to be added to the implant. After enough crimes in enough cities, the offender will be unable to enter civilization again.

Prisons of the 2000's are horrendously overcrowded and deadly. After the riots of the 90's, prison authorities couldn't care less about rehabilitation—they are mostly interested in penning up society's "mad dogs" and keeping the streets clear. To cope with overcrowding, many prisons force inmates into "braindance"—they are placed in cryo tanks, wired to interface loop programs, and "shut down" for periods of two or three years. Continuous braindance creates a nightmare of unending, bland horror, making it the thing cons fear most.

The simplest method of punishment is still execution. Most states have a State Executioner who administers justice with one well placed .44 slug at point blank range. He is also empowered to hunt down escapees from Death Row.

Weapons

By 1997, even the most well-intentioned gun control statutes were buried under a wave of public protest as crime rates made America a siege state. Self-defense soon became an American lifestyle, and there was an explosive increase in light personal protection weapons.

By 1999, most gun control statutes involved 1) filling out a "carry application" allowing you to carry a concealed handgun; 2) waiting 4 days for an extensive background check and approval, which could be refused on the basis of a criminal record or history of mental illness; and 3) paying the $25.00 fee and having a serial number laser etched into the butt of the gun. This number is cataloged with the ballistics firing pattern of your weapon at FBI/CIA Headquarters in Washington D.C.

The Federal Weapons Statute of 1999 states that if a gun with your ID number is used in the commission of a crime, you are liable for that crime, unless you have previously reported the weapon as lost or stolen, and have had this report filed with your local police agency.

Under the provisions of the Federal Weapons Statute, it is not legal to carry submachineguns and other fully automatic weapons—possession carries a stiff 5 to 7 year mandatory prison sentence. Not that this stops anyone.

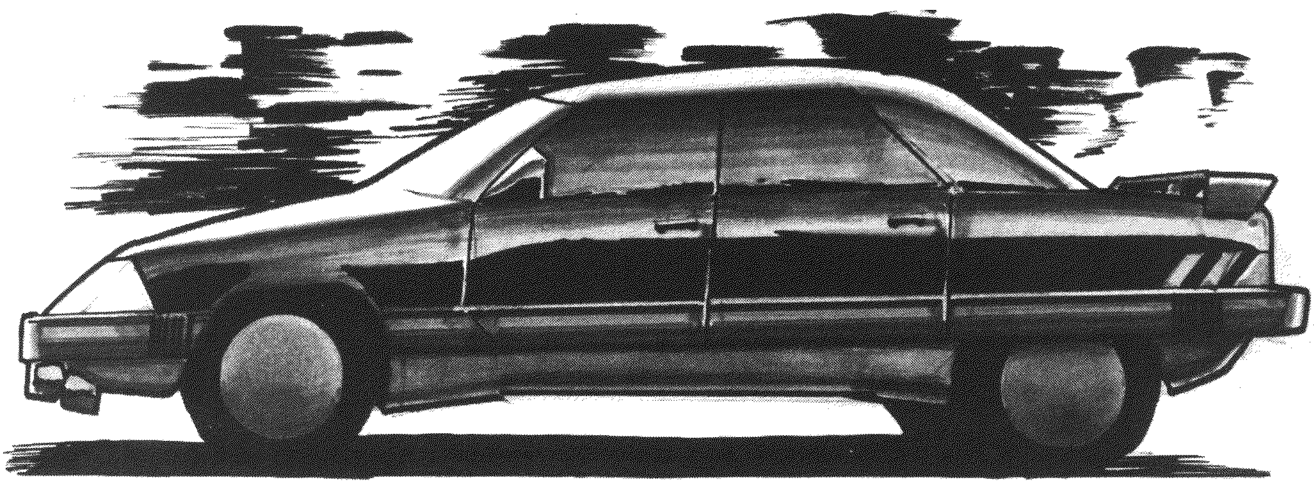
While there's a certain style in using an old model sidearm like a Colt .357 or .45, the sensible cyberpunk knows that a modern pistol makes a good backup. Since the introduction of the Glock 17 automatic in the mid-1980's, most major handgun manufacturers now produce polymer resin pistols in a variety of calibers.

The most ubiquitous of these is the Federated Arms X-22 and X-9 series, a line of polymer plastic handguns. Manufactured in a variety of bright, designer colors, these so-called "Polymer One-shots" carry an easy to load 10 or 8 round clips of caseless ammunition, retail at $150 to $300, and are available in most sporting goods stores. They combine practicality, durability and style in potent little packages. The new *Cyberteen*™ line includes airbrushed casings with colorful shapes and artwork molded right in—the perfect gift for the young consumer interested in personal defense.

Vehicles

Surprise, surprise. Contrary to expectations, the year 2000 has not yielded any staggering new developments in transportation. Years of economic strife

Toyo-Chrysler Omega
A typical medium sedan. Top speed about 90mph. Pr:ce around 10,000eb.



and civil unrest have discouraged research into new ways to travel—in fact, the very act of travel has become very restricted. Expect the inner city world of 2020 to be much like the 20th century—a network of crowded freeways, packed trains, and swarming airports.

Automobile

(Manufactured by Ford-Mazda, New American Motor, Toyo-Chrysler, Yugo-Marakovka, BMW, Mercedes, Porsche, etc.)
Powerplant: Alcohol or methane fueled internal combustion.
Groundspeed: 100 to 160mph.
Structural Damage Points: 50. Armored cars may have up to 30 SP of armor on all surfaces including windows.
There haven't been any major changes in automobiles since the 1980's—externally. Most cars are still basically a box on wheels, with smooth or hard edges. The *Cyberpunk* ethos being, "if it works, keep it till it doesn't work." In the cash poor environment of the 2000's, auto manufacturers have kept to conservative, unimaginative designs, so that by today,, the average family car is little changed from it's practically antique Ford or Toyota roots.

With the extremely high price of petroleum, almost all cars of the 2000's are powered by tanks of liquified methane or meta-alcohol fuels such as "CHOOH-2." Electric cars are the exception, not the rule. Control systems are roughly like those of the late 20th century employing a few more digital displays and pushbutton controls.

The biggest change has come with the introduction of cybernetic control systems. These employ servos at the wheels, throttle and transmission, which are controlled by a modified cybermodem in the dash. The driver simply "studs" into the cybermodem and thinks the car through the motions. Cybervehicles are relatively uncommon—the upgrading price is steep, and the removal of external controls renders the vehicle useless to anyone but a cybered driver. So far, no major manufacturer has produced a purely cyber-driven automobile, although there are several after-market firms which will convert a standard car to cyber control.

Bell Boeing V-22B Osprey

Powerplant: Allison 937 Gas Turbine
Performance: Max speed=275 knots. Range=600 miles
Structural Damage Points: 200 (Ospreys are not armored).

The Osprey mounts two large, wide propped engine nacelles at the ends of long, high-lift wings. The engines can be tilted from a forward facing direction to a vertical position, allowing the aircraft to take off and hover vertically. The wings can be folded back along the body for easy storage, making the Osprey a perfect vehicle to work from rooftop airpads and unprepared airstrips.

A revolutionary concept when it was unveiled in 1988, the Osprey tilt rotor aircraft has become a standard vehicle throughout the 2000's. The military version served with distinction throughout the riots of the 90's and the Central American Conflicts. Various civilian manufacturers (Cessna, Lear, Avionica) have licenced the original Boeing design and applied it to smaller commercial and business applications. The Lear Tiltjet even applies the Osprey principles to a tiltwinged turbojet version.

Ospreys can be found as commuter vehicles between city centers and hub airports, or as corporate aircraft operating from rooftop pads atop headquarters skyscrapers. Small versions such as Cessna's AE-800 Featherlite are popular light aircraft throughout the world, allowing flight operations in even the most remote and unprepared sites.

Light Rail Lev Train

Numerous Manufacturers
Powerplant: Electric third rail inductance field.
Groundspeed: 200 mph.
Structural Damage Points: 80 per car of train.
Superconductor magnets have made it possible to build extremely cheap and durable "levitation trains." Riding on magnetic cushions, these "levs" have become one of the major transportation resources in the 2000's. Financed by Corporations or city governments, they are present in most major cities.

Levs are usually underground within the city limits, running on high pillars out in the suburbs. Usually one line, headed out to the Corporate suburbs, is sealed off and requires an entry code or pass to get into that station. Corporate lev stations are always clean, well lit, and well guarded by corporate security. City lev-stations are usually not up to these standards, although most cities run police patrols on the line to control crime and vandalism.

Lev-tickets are charged at a rate of 50¢ per station passed; a trip passing through three stations, for example, would cost 1.50eb. Tickets may be purchased from automatic ticket machines, using credit cards or cash. These machines are located in the stations themselves and in local convenience store outlets.

Bell F-152 Aerogyro

Powerplant: one Bell-Mazda 2600 rotary aircraft engine.
Performance: Max airspeed: 300 mph. Operational radius: 50 miles.
Structural Damage Points: 40
The riots of the late 90's required new tactics for operating in urban areas. Chief among these was the introduction of light, one man helicopters or aerogyros. The F-152 is currently used by police units, Corporate defense teams, Solo assault operations teams and drug-running gangs. An unarmed version, known as the Bell-15, is a popular recreational vehicle.

McDonnell-Douglas AV-4 Tactical Urban Assault Vehicle

Powerplant: one Rolls-Royce Pegasus II Vectored Thrust Turbofan (21,180 lbs thrust)
Performance: Max airspeed: 350 mph. Operational radius: 400 miles.
Structural Damage Points: 100. Most AV-4s are armored to an SP of 40.

The nearest thing to a science fiction jet-car, the AV-4 Tac Vehicle was developed as a light assault aircraft capable of operation in close urban areas where rotary and tiltwing aircraft cannot penetrate. Short, bulbous, and equipped with only rudimentary manuver wings, the AV-4 has the aerodynamic characteristics of a rock, relying on the brute force of it's huge jet engine to keep it aloft (the original Pegasus engine lifted a 19,550 lb Harrier jumpjet, while a fully loaded AV-4 weighs about 8,600 lbs).

The AV-4 is used by police or corporate troops for urban assaults (using 2 belly mounted GAU-12U minigun pods). They are also used as emergency vehicles—specifically by the Trauma Team organizations—or as corporate vehicles for special deliveries and meetings.

AV-6 Combat Assault Aerodyne

Powerplant: two Rolls-Royce Pegasus IV Vectored Thrust Turbofans
Performance: Max airspeed: 480 mph. Operational radius: 600 miles.
Structural Damage Points: 100. Most AV-6s' are armored to an SP of 40.
This is a high speed, fully combat capable version of the AV-4 aerodyne, with fans mounted in heavily armored side housings. AV-6's mount cyberassisted chin turrets (20mm cannon), plus rockets and missiles. AV-6's are primarily used by military units.

AV-7 Personal Aerodyne

Powerplant: one Rolls-Royce Pegasus Mini-Turbofan.
Performance: Max airspeed: 250 mph. Operational radius: 400 miles.
Structural Damage Points: 50.
A recent development of the AV classes, these are small aerodyne vehicles designed to fulfill the light helicopter role. While the internal avionics and engines are usually designed by Douglas, a unique licencing arrangement permits other vehicle manufacturers to build their own body shells on the basic chassis. Manufacturers now include BMW, Mercedes, Toyota and Maserati.

Information Services

Letter

A **stamp** in 2020 costs 95 eurocents. There are usually two deliveries—once in the morning at 10.00 a.m. and once in the afternoon at 3.00 p.m. Letters are normally used for personal correspondence, or in regions where Fax machines are not available.

Data Term

The **Data Term** is a streetcorner computer terminal, built into a heavily armored concrete post. Data Terms have a direct Net link to a central Data Term service in their home city, and can provide maps of the area, information, news updates, phone numbers, current events and entertainment information and shopping services. Data Terms may also be used to jack into the Net. Rates are about 1eb per minute.

Most Data Terms are operated by a local DT service, which is often a subsidiary of a local newspaper or screamsheet publisher.

Fax

This is the letterwriting mode of the

future. Fax terminals are located in most corporate offices, post offices, computer shops, malls and convenience stores. You may type your letter in using the keyboard provided, have it scanned from your own laser disk, or use the built-in scanner to "read"any typed letter. The faxed copy is then transmitted by wire to a local post office in your destination area, where it is automatically typed off, inserted into an envelope, and delivered by letter carrier to the mailbox. Fax copies may also be sent directly to a Fax receiver at your destination. Fax letters costs 1eb per page.

Cellular Phones

The phone of the future is mobile and cordless, allowing the cyberpunk on the go to talk from his car, office, or even on the street. These "cellular" phones operate by using a series of stationary transceivers which pick up your phone signal and relay it into the regular phone Net. Calls can be made not only from within the city, but also long distance (with a Long Distance service of your choice) all over the world and even into orbit.

Cellular phones come in a variety of brands and styles, although most are about the size of a hand held walky-talky. They operate on rechargeable batteries good for about 12 hours, recharging from a wall socket in 6 hours. Brand names include Magnavox, NEC, Okidata, GE and Radio Shack. Prices range from $400.00 for an inexpensive model, to $3,000.00 for models with multiple lines, built in hold-buttons and memory-autodial.

Like other phones, you must pay a monthly service charge. Baseline rates are $40.00 per month plus 20¢ per minute for local calls. Long Distance varies—a call from Los Angeles to New York might cost $2.00 per minute during daylight business hours, $1.50 for evening hours. Cell phones also have a limit on how far they can operate outside of the city limits; about 20 miles.

Screamsheets

To stay competitive with television, most newspapers now use Fax technology. Entire pages are typeset and laid out by computer, photos scanned into places, and the entire newspaper reduced to digital code. This code is transmitted to hundreds of newspaper boxes all over the area. The newsboxes reassemble the code and print the paper (using high speed xerography) on the spot. The result is a slick, flimsy newspaper known in streetslang as a screamsheet.

Screamsheets have many advantages over previous newspapers. You can dial the newsbox to print only the sections of the paper you want, paying 1¢ per page printed. New editions can be compiled in hours, allowing the public to keep abreast of a story even as it happens (although most screamsheets are updated at 6:00 a.m., 12:00 p.m., 5:00 p.m. and 10:00 p.m.).

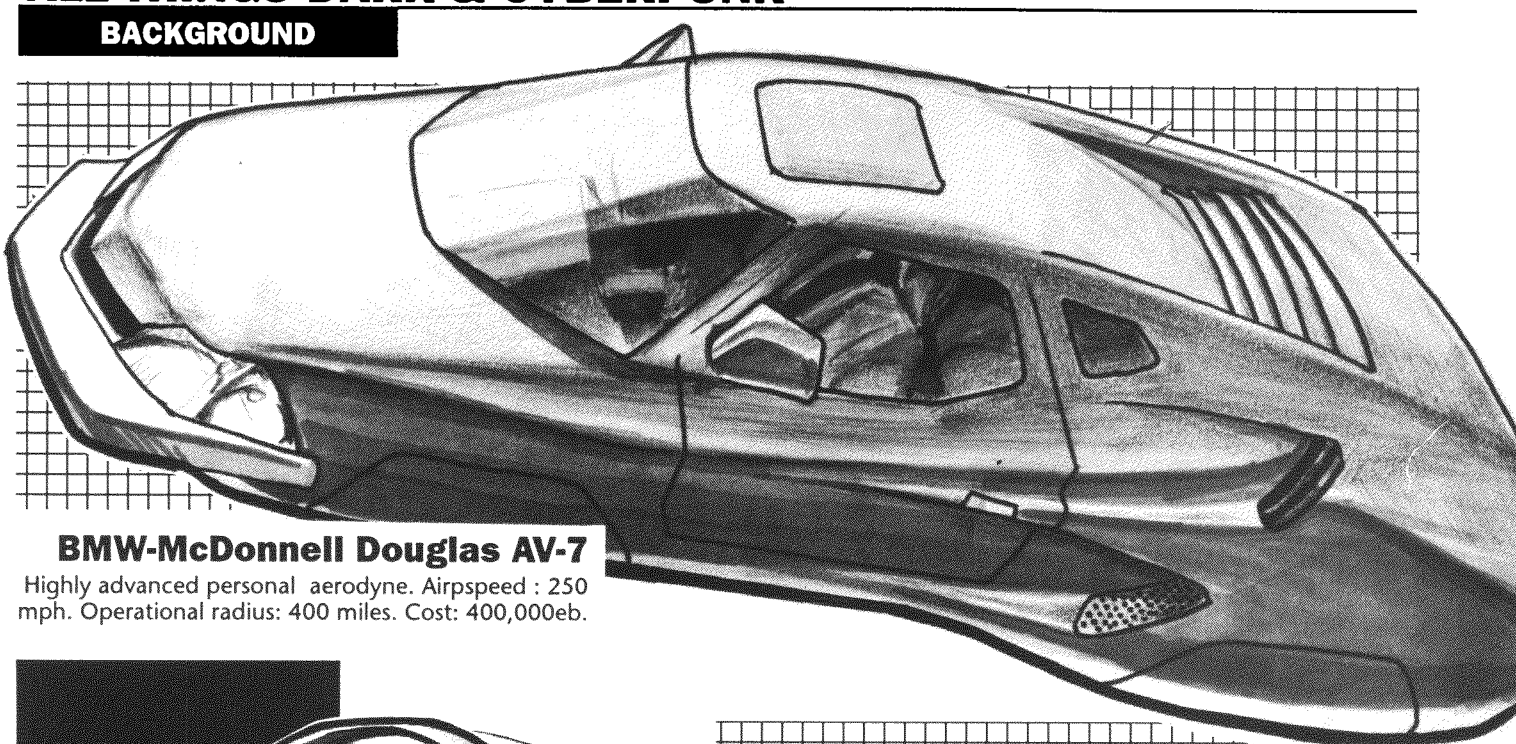
Television & Radio

An all pervasive force in 2020, television has moved into the realm of total entertainment. One hundred and eighty one channels now crowd the airwaves, as well as various cable and subscriber channels. These cover everything including sports, news, music video, old movies, foreign shows, religious programming, debate, erotic and adult programming, business news and weather. In addition, there are at least 200,000 radio stations throughout the Western world.

In the Euro and Asian theaters, most programming is state-controlled; the BBC in Great Britain, and NGK TV in Japan, for example. In the United States, three privately owned entertainment networks predominate: 21st Century Broadcasting Network (CBN), World Broadcasting Network (WBN) and Network News 54. These networks are the broadcast divisions of three massive entertainment conglomerates, each producing records, tapes, videos, movies and books for the masses. The product is bland, mindless, and caters to the lowest possible denominator.

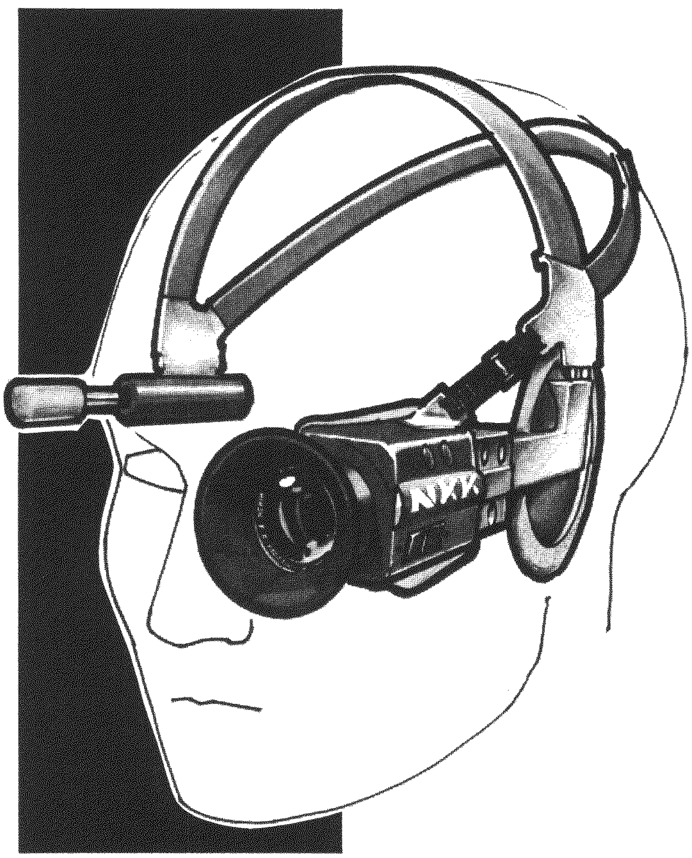
In addition to network programming, there are satellite feeds, featuring programming from around the world. There are also a large number of "pirate" TV stations, operating out of hidden stations and through cable and satellite patchups. These are often a major source of news and information untainted by corporate and government interference.

In addition to the now standard **high definition** flatscreen TV, experimental (and expensive; up to 10,000.000 per set) holographic TV systems are now available.



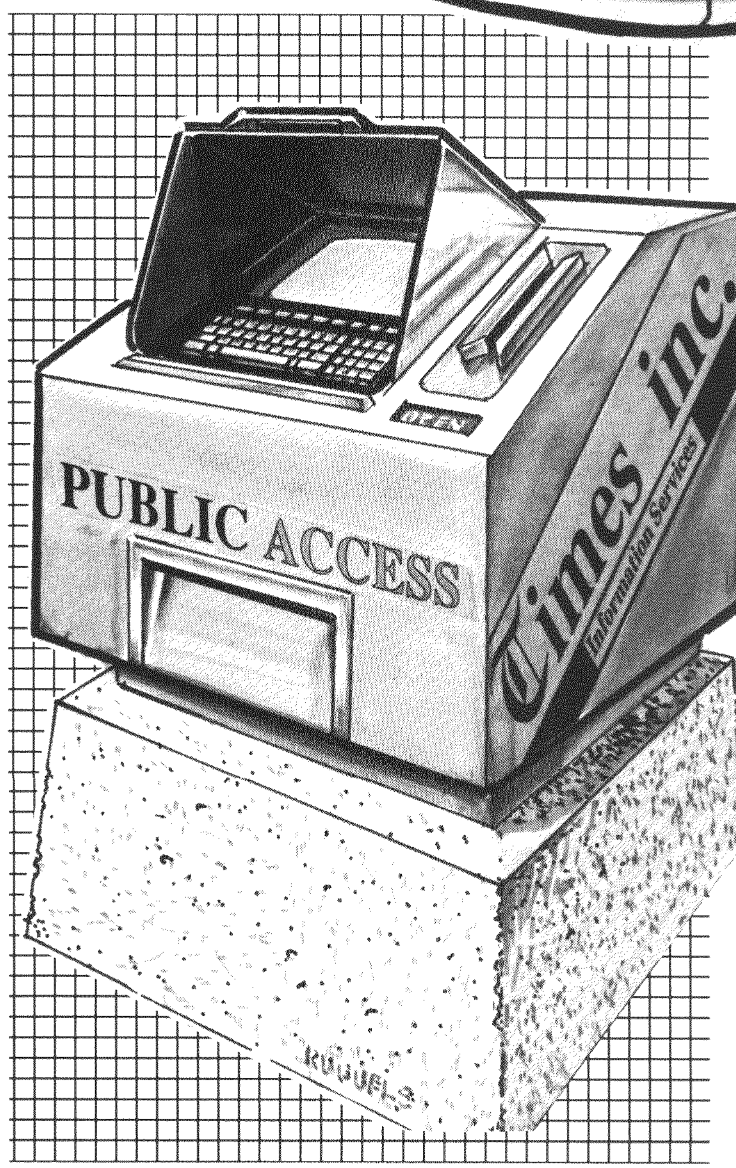
BMW-McDonnell Douglas AV-7

Highly advanced personal aerodyne. Airpspeed : 250 mph. Operational radius: 400 miles. Cost: 400,000eb.



Zetatech Hi-Profile® VideoCam

A favorite design used by Medias for mobile assignments. Pickup mike range is 200 feet. Cellular uplink allows instant transmission to Network broadcast studio. Cost is 875eb.

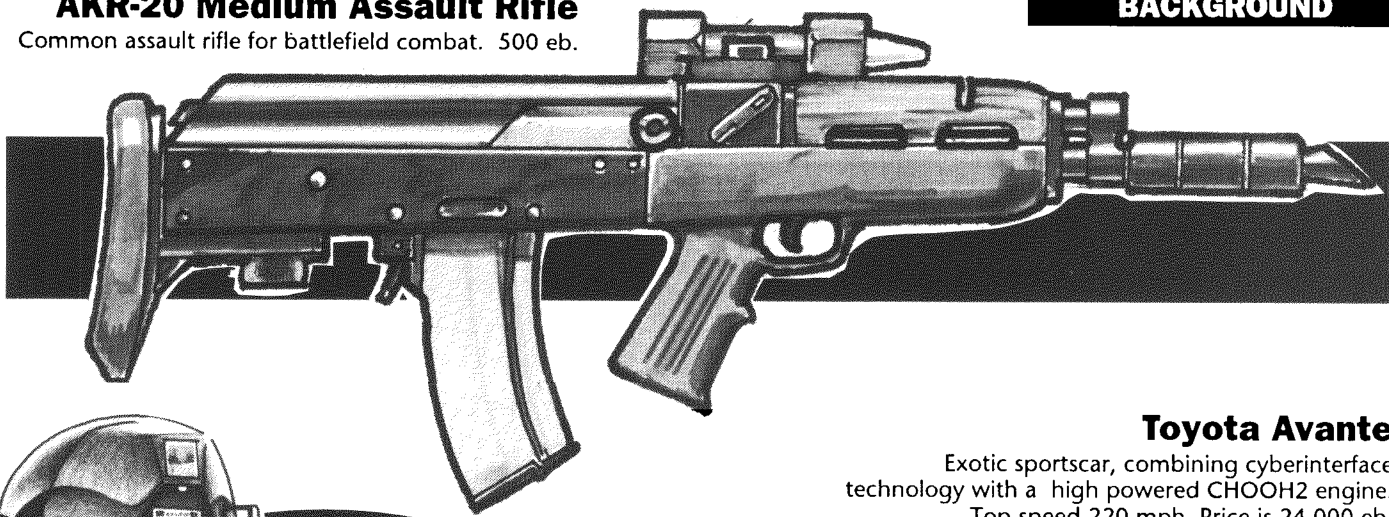


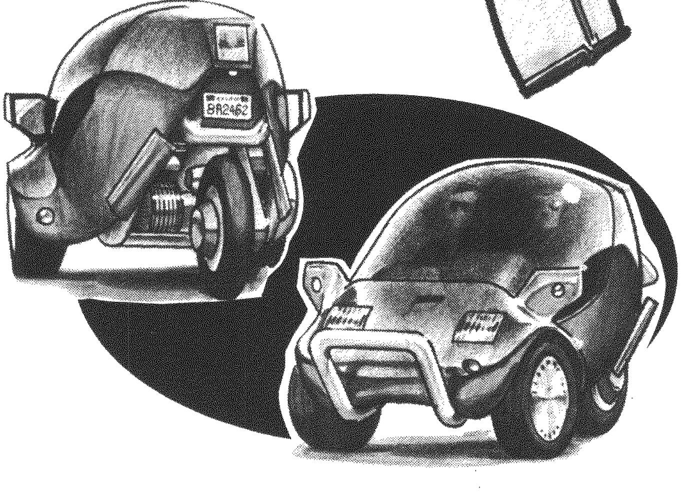
Dataterm

Providing news, information, weather reports, entertainment news. Data Terms may also be used to access the Net and to make phone calls. 1eb per minute use.

AKR-20 Medium Assault Rifle

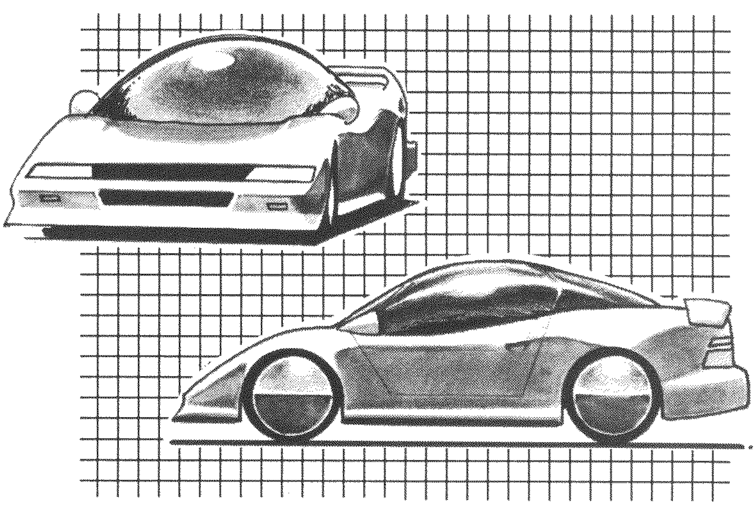
Common assault rifle for battlefield combat. 500 eb.





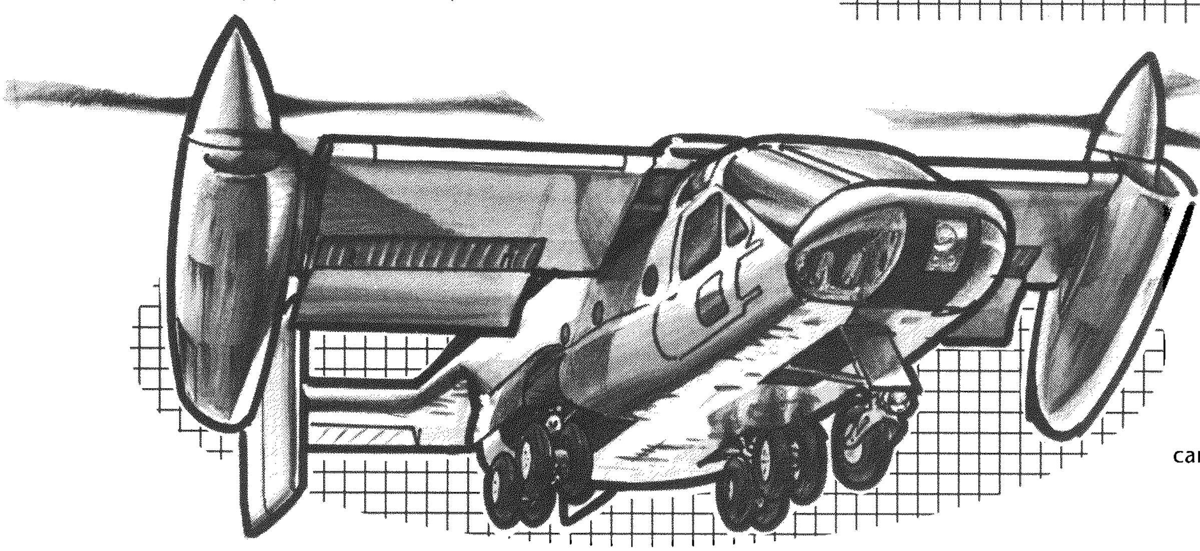
Toyota Avante

Exotic sportscar, combining cyberinterface technology with a high powered CHOOH2 engine. Top speed 220 mph. Price is 24,000 eb.



Honda Metrocar

Common type of city car, powered by $CHOOH^2$. Top speed about 40mph. About 2000eb.

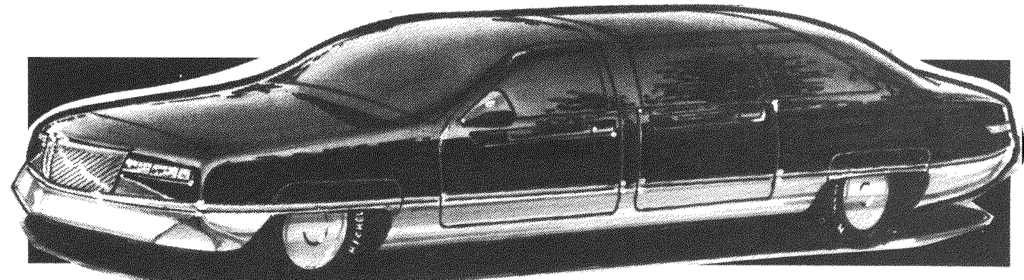


Bell-Boeing V-22F Osprey

Heavy lift version of the original tilt-rotor craft, capable of airlifting large cargos to isolated areas. Cost 750,000 eb.

Ford-Mazda Luxus 14

Cybercontrolled luxury car, favored by many high level Corporates execs. About 40,000 eb.



"Life in 2020 isn't just all guns and drugs. If it was, we woulda named the game Dungeons & Drug Dealers.

The best Cyberpunk games are a combination of doomed romance, fast action, glittering parties, mean streets and quixotic quests to do the right thing against all odds. It's a little like Casablanca with cyberware..."

—Maximum Mike

SECTION

12 RUNNING CYBERPUNK

Assorted tips, clues, good stuff and tricks of the Cyberpunk genre

So how do I run this game?

Glad you asked. *Cyberpunk* is a challenge for even an experienced Referee, in that you must create the right atmosphere of grunginess, sleek technology and pervasive paranoia throughout your entire game. The *Cyberpunk* environment is almost always exclusively urban. Its landscape is a maze of towering skyscrapers, burned out ruins, dingy tenements and dangerous alleyways. In short, any major city in the world at about 2:30 in the morning when the lowlifes come out in force.

The Urban Environment

The urban environment is critical to your *Cyberpunk* world. Whether you use our *Night City* or create your own, remember that your setting has to have all the right elements. There should be garbage-strewn alleyways. There should be bodies lying in the gutters. There should be wild-eyed lunatics, staggering through pre-dawn streets, muttering darkly and clutching sharp knives. Taxis won't stop in the combat zones. There are firefights at the streetcorner as the local gangs slug it out. Players should find their apartments regularly broken into, their cars vandalized, their property stolen. Crossing town should be like crossing a battlefield, filled with looters, riots, crazies and muggers.

And it always rains. Every day should be grim, gloomy and overcast. The stars never come out. The sun never shines. There are no singing birds, no laughing children. (The last bird died in 2008 and the kids are grown in vats.) The ozone layer decayed, the greenhouse effect took over, the sky is full of hydrocarbons and the ocean full of sludge. Nice place.*

* Okay, we're exaggerating. But not much.

Trust No One. Keep your...er..Minami 10 Handy

Paranoia is important in a *Cyberpunk* run. Players shouldn't be able to tell who are the good guys and who are the bad just by looking at them. Choices between sides should be ambiguous—there should be no clear cut sense of good and evil, much like real life. Sworn enemies may be thrown together without notice or preparation. Heroes may have to do something illegal or distasteful to accomplish something good; villians may have to do a little good once in a while. It's the breaks.

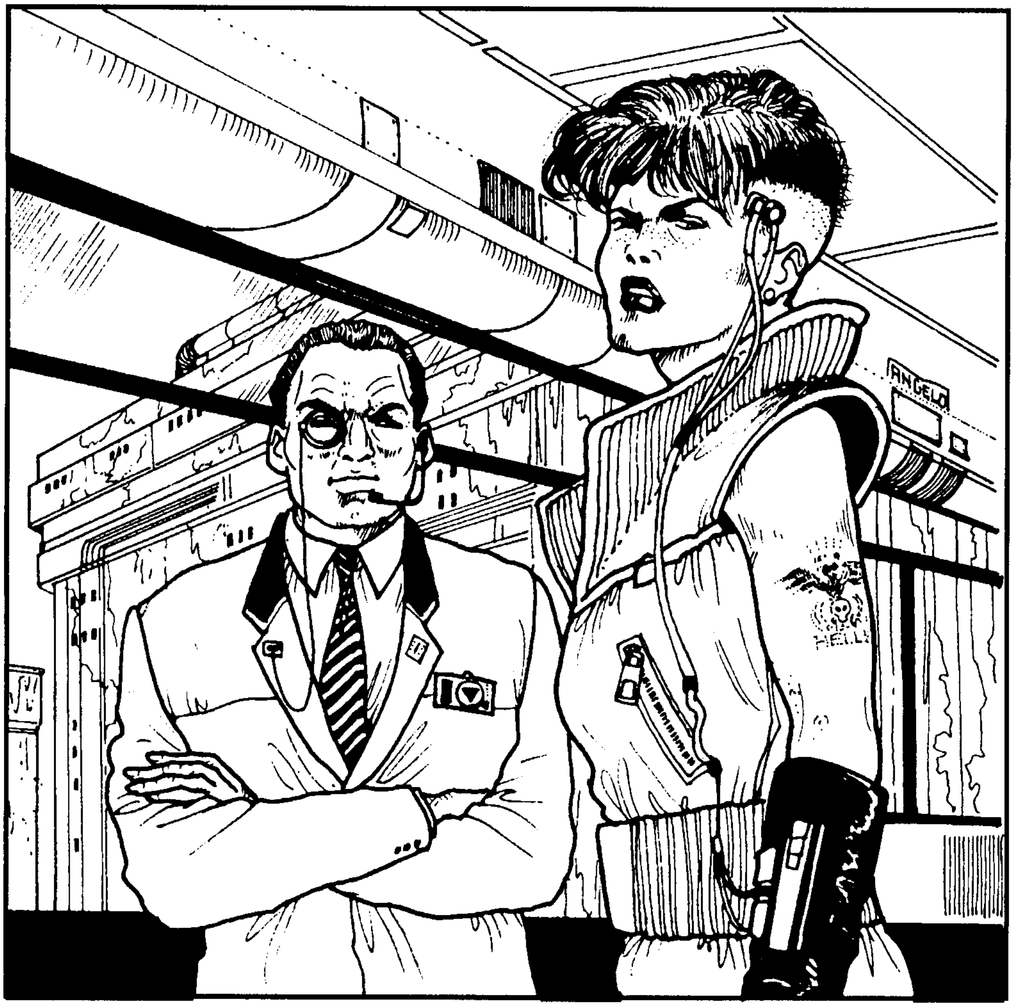
Your world should have staggering contrasts. In the glittering citadels of the rich, there should be fine food, expensive vices, and beautiful scenery. On the Street, things should be cold, hungry and desperate. There's no middle ground between the haves and have nots. It's all or nothing.

Know The World

First trick to running Cyberpunk: **Immerse yourself in the genre**. We've given you a start with the story *Never Fade Away*—it should give you the style of speech, the urban feel, and the hard-edged realities of the *Cyberpunk* world. But you should also hit the local video-store, the library and the record shops for source material. We've included a bibliography of places to start in the sidebar.

Play For Keeps

Second trick to running *Cyberpunk*: **Play hard and fast.** You should not be afraid to kill off player characters. You should constantly be getting them into fights, traps, betrayals and other soap operas. There should be no one they can trust entirely, no



place that's absolutely safe. Never let 'em rest. This doesn't mean you shouldn't play fair. But you should always play for keeps. If they cache weapons somewhere, steal them. If they stop for a rest, mug them. If they can't handle the pressure, they shouldn't be playing *Cyberpunk*. Send them back to that nice role-playing game with the happy elves and the singing birds. We've given you some great encounter tables which we suggest you use everytime the action drags (in *Friday Night Firefight*).

Set the Mood

Third trick to running *Cyberpunk*: Atmosphere. Get out your heaviest rock tapes and play them during your run. Encourage your players to wear leather and mirrorshades. Adopt the slang and invent your own. Replace all the lights in your room with dim blue bulbs. This is the dark future here; and it can't be accurately portrayed in a brightly lit room with milk and cookies on the table.

Teamwork; The More the Bloodier

Fourth and last trick to running *Cyberpunk*: **Teams**. You'll notice—*Cyberpunk* groups are not social. The players will have no reason to trust anyone, and the conventional reasons (stop evil, kill monsters) for an adventuring party won't work. A bar isn't a place to meet new adventurers—it's a place to scope out potential victims. Parties are more likely to kill each other in a firefight than divide the spoils fairly.

For this reason, you'll need a more solid "hook" on which to hang a *Cyberpunk* adventure. Our hook is the team. A team is a group of people who are already thrown together by Fate in some way which forces them to co-operate. They don't have to like each other, but they have to work together. Besides giving the party a springboard from which to work, the team also makes the adventure easier to run. Players

A CYBERPUNK BIBLIOGRAPHY

Just a few of the most well known books in the cyberpunk genre:

William Gibson
Neuromancer
Count Zero
Mona Lisa Overdrive
Burning Chrome

Norman Spinrad
Little Heroes

John G. Batancourt
Johnny Zed

Joan D. Vinge
Psion
Catspaw

Mick Farren
Vickers

Walter Jon Williams
Hardwired
Voice of the Whirlwind
Angel Station

Bruce Sterling
The Artificial Kid
Mirrorshades: The Cyberpunk Anthology
Islands in the Net

John Brunner
Shockwave Rider

George Alec Effinger
When Gravity Fails
A Fire in the Sun

Steve Barnes
Streetlethal
Gorgon Child

John Shirley
Eclipse
Eclipse Penumbra

Rudy Rucker
Softwear
Wetware